

ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN TO 1270

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UNIT ONE

INTRODUCTION TO HISTORY

1.1 WHAT IS HISTORY

In simplest terms, history is the story of the human experience. No one can know about everything that happened in the past. Thus, history is an organized and systematic study of the past. In the past, history teaching originally focused on the facts of political history such as wars and dynasties. Contemporary history education, however, has assumed a more integrative approach offering students an expanded view of historical knowledge that includes aspects of geography, religion, anthropology, philosophy, economics, technology, art and society. The experts who study history are called historians. They study all aspects of human life (i.e. social, cultural, economic and political in the past).

What distinguishes history from other social sciences is that it studies the interaction of man and his natural environment through the passage of time while other disciplines study man and nature in their present state. Arising from this fact is the central importance of time. Because of the length of that time, historians divide their study into different periods of time. For example, they divide the human past into two major categories. These are:

i) Pre-history: is the study of the past before the evolution of complex social and political organizations. It can also be defined as the study of human past before the origin of writing or the production of written records.

ii) History: on the other hand, studies the period after the beginning of writing.

To make the study of history easier and more convenient, historians have divided the discipline into three periods. These are Ancient, Medieval, and Modern.

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Graphically, the eras of history can be shown as follows.

1500 AD- Hoyages of Discovery	Modern Era (time)	- Space case
		- World war
		- Industrialism
		- Niberal revolution
	Middle Ages	- Conquest of the Americas
		- Renaissance
		- Mongol conquests
		- Maya civilization
500 AO- Fall of classical civilization	Ancient Times	- rise of Island
		- Dark ages in Europe
		- classical Greece and Rome
		- Southern ocean trade
350 Bc. Writing and civilization	Pre- History	- ancient India and China
		- Egypt of the phrahs
		- civilization arises in Mesopotamia
		- agriculture
		- spoken language
		- tools
		- emergence of humans
		- the big bang

Focus

Absolute truth is a rare commodity.

Still, it is important to mention that the above division of history into three is merely for the sake of convenience. This is because history is a continuous process. That is, events and processes that took place in ancient and medieval times have their effects in modern times. Thus, in one form or another, the past continues to live in the present. Continuity as well as change can be seen in the way in which people earned and continue to earn their livelihood, in their religious beliefs and practices, and in their dress styles interaction. Accordingly, history can also be defined as the interaction between change and continuity.

As the past lives in the present, we are also interested in our past. Talking about the past is a common human preoccupation. As we knew, in Ethiopia, names like Axum, Gragn, Gada, Adwa are still very much alive with us. Much is written and spoken about them.

1.2 SOURCES OF HISTORY

Where there is no record, there is no history.

Sources are the key to the study and writing of history. They are the bases of those statements and judgments. They form the reliable bridge that connects the historian to the past. They are the instruments that bring to life what appear to have been dead. Good sources make possible the writing of good history.

Sources are imperfect and fragmentary. They were created for purposes differently from those of the historian. Often, sources have been destroyed in a course of time. Therefore, apart from the complex range of questions, which have to be posed, there is a problem of unreliability or unsatisfactory nature of sources for questions historians wish to address.

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Historians divide sources into primary and secondary.

1.3 PRIMARY SOURCES

They are records that come directly from the period under investigation. They are original or first hand in their proximity and immediacy to the event both in time and space. The historian usually refers to those sources, which are closest in time and space to the event in question. The primary sources of history are documents written by those who participated in or witnessed the event you're studying. From very early periods there may be only a few surviving documents which are contemporary or nearly contemporary with the event in question. Primary sources are obtained in two ways :

- I. For ancient times, from archaeological excavations.
- II. For more recent times, from archives and libraries.

TYPES OF PRIMARY SOURCES

A. Inscriptions: In Ethiopia, inscriptions were written in four different languages: Sabeans, Greek, Ge'ez and Arabic. Sabeian was introduced by south Arabians and was spoken in northern Ethiopia for about 1,000 years. The Sabeian inscriptions were written in Boustrophedon style (from left to right and then from right to left). The longest inscription was in Greek at Adulis. The other is the inscription of Ezana which was written in Ge'ez, Sabeian and Greek.

The following are pre-Christian and Christian inscriptions of king Ezana. Read them.

1. Pre-Christian Inscription of King Ezana

Ezana, the son of Ella Amida, Bisi Halen, king of Aksum, Himyar, Raydan, Saba, Salhin, Tsiyamo, Beja and of Kasu, son of the invincible Mahrem. The Tsarane, whose country is Afan, attacked and annihilated a merchant caravan. And we went to war against them, and we sent columns, those of Mahaza, Daken and Hara and we ourselves followed and camped at the place of encampment of the troops at Ala and from there we sent out our troops: And they killed some of the Tsarane, and captured others and took booty. We vanquished Sa ene and Tsawant and Gema and Zahatan, four peoples, and we seized Alita and his two children. An 503 men of Afan and 202 women were put to death, in all 705. Men and their women were made prisoner, 40 men and 165 women, total 205. The booty comprised 31,900 head of cattle and 827 beasts of burden. And the [the king]

returned in safety with his people and raised a throne here-in Shado which he put under the protection of the gods Astar, Beher and Meder. And should anyone remove or displace it, let him and his race be exterminated, let him be extirpated from these lands. And he brought a thank-offering to Mahrem who begot him, 100 head of cattle and 50 captives.

2. Christian Inscription of King Ezana

In the faith of God and the power of the Father, son and Holy Spirit who saved for me the kingdom, by the faith of his son Jesus Christ, who has helped me and will always help me. I Azanas king of the Aksumites, and Himyarites, and Reidan and of the Sabaeans and of Sileel and of Knaso and of the Beja and of Tiamo, Bisi Alen, son of Ella Amida servant of Christ thank the Lord my God, and I am unable to state fully his favours because my mouth and my mind cannot (embrace) all the favours which he has given me, for he has given name through his son in whom I believed. And he made me the guide of all my kingdom because of my faith in Christ by his will and in the power of Christ, for he has guided me. And I believe in him and he became to me a guide. I went out to fight the Noba because there cried out against them, the Mangartha and Khasa and Atiaditai and Bareotai saying that “the Noba have ground us down, help us because they have troubled us by killing”. And I left by the power of Christ the God in whom I have believed and he has guided me and I departed from Aksum on the eighth day, a Saturday, of the Aksumite month of Magabit having faith in God and arrived in Mambarya and there I fed my army.

B. Government and church records.

Censuses, court records, birth, death, marriage and burial records are important sources of information.

C. Artifacts

Buildings, tools, clothing, toys, furniture and other household items can all reveal aspects of the lives of the people who made and used them. Contemporary paintings and drawings can also be used to show how clothing was worn, how artifacts were used, and how people wished to be represented.

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D. Coins: The minting of coins in Ethiopia started in about 3rd century AD and continued up to the 10th C. Coins in Axum were minted from gold, silver, iron and bronze. Until the introduction of Christianity to Aksum, the coins bore pagan symbols, the crescent and disc. But after the introduction of Christianity they bore Christian symbol, the cross. The coins of Ethiopia are invaluable sources in historical writing of the period. They give as accurate information about the history, art, and religion of the Axumite Empire. They also tell us the role of Aksum in the international trade.

Generally, letters, decrees, ruins of buildings, monuments, tools, ornaments, pottery, temples, churches, altars, diaries and others are primary sources. Travelers account is usually considered as primary sources if it is an eye witness. Concerning oral sources, freshness and nearness in distance determine whether they are primary or secondary, i.e., whether an informant was present on the spot when the event took place or was far from it. Therefore, oral informants may or may not be primary sources based on time and space.

Among the monuments, the Axum stelae is the most prominent one. The longest stela was about 33m but now it is broken down. The other was taken by Italian (now, returned) while the third one is still standing. It is 23m long. The purpose of erecting stela is unknown. But we have two assumptions:

- i) They could erect on the tombs of Axumite kings like that of Egyptian pyramids.
- ii) They were created for son- gods. There are no inscriptions on stela Aksum.

They were erected from living rocks. Thousands of people might involve erecting them.

2.4 SECONDARY SOURCES

These are not first hand sources. They are removed in both space and time. They are not direct products of the period under study. They are sometimes referred to as historical reconstructions because what the historian does is to reconstruct the past on the basis of the available sources. For example, a letter from Emperor Tewodros to queen Victoria is a primary source; where as a history book written in the eightieth century using that sources is a secondary one. Secondary sources are mostly books, articles, and etc. Example : Babru Zewde. *A History of Modern Ethiopia. 1855-1991*.

Secondary sources can be based on primary sources but they are reconstructions and interpretations. So the authors manipulate the primary sources. How sharp the author in his methodology and argument matters who the historian is. That is, the reliability and authenticity of the work depends on who is to write. To elaborate this, you have a guitar and with it you can play Amharic music but it depends on who is to play it. Similarly, the facts are available to the historian in documents, inscriptions and so on. The historian collects them and then manipulates them in whatever style appeals to him.

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All these tell us the necessity of examining and cross checking sources before using them. Appropriate facts should be selected, processed, arranged and interpreted. Primary source is raw or crude data but the secondary sources are processed so the fact that it (secondary sources) is ready made and processed has an advantage.

In anyway, whatever the nature of the sources, primary or secondary, written or oral, historians should always make use of a critical way of evaluation. Assessment is valid for both primary and secondary sources. Primary sources have to be verified for their authenticity because some times primary sources like letters may be forged.

Evaluating the information we find in books, journals and on the internet is an important process in our academic work. Not all information sources will be authoritative, reliable, or well researched, but this does not mean they are not valuable for our field of study. After we have identified our information source, we need to assess how the source contributes to knowledge in our discipline. Here are some questions to guide us through the process of critical evaluation of information sources:

1. Relevance:

Is the document related to our topic?

2. Authority:

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Is the author a scholarly or popular writer?

Is the author a recognized authority in this field of study?

Do other authors quote from this author's works?

3. Timeliness:

When was the document written?

4. Validity, Accuracy:

Is the data from a valid study?

5. Argument:

Are there any flaws in the author's logic?

Does the author consider alternate interpretations of the evidence?

is the author attempting to deceive or manipulate readers?

6. Coverage:

Does the author use information or data that was available at the time the work was published?

Did the author consider all aspects relevant to the topic?

7. Bias or Prejudice

Does the author state any bias?

If you discovered any omissions in the coverage of the topic, did this reveal a bias or prejudice?

In the study of non-literate societies, historians use oral information. Historians gather oral information and oral tradition through interviews. But they should be very selective in conducting interviews. In many societies, oral information can pass from one generation to another without being recorded. This type of oral history is called oral tradition. Through time, however, an oral tradition may lose its originality and authenticity (truth) as a result of omission, exaggeration and distortion. In that case, the story may become a myth.

In conclusion, before using any sources, a historian should ask the following:

- Is the source authentic?
- Where did the source come from?

- When exactly was the source produced?
- What type of source is it ?
- Who produced the source?

1.5 THE USES OF HISTORY

The past does not exist now. It has gone for good. In actual fact, however, the past continues to live in the present. It, therefore affects our present and future lives. History makes as better thinkers and informed citizens. History the purpose of historical study is not simply to present facts but to search for an interpretation of the past Historians attempt to find patterns and establish meaning through the rigorous study of documents and artifacts left by people of other times and other places.

Focus

The past does not exist now. It has gone for good. In actual fact, however, the past continues to live in the present. It, therefore, affects our present and future lives.

History is functional because it meets the needs of the society. We study history because people want to know themselves. A society without memory (history) found great difficulty in relating to others and in taking intelligent decisions. It is only through sense of history that communities established their identify orient themselves, understand their relationships with the past and to other societies. Societies have felt a need to produce some sort of account of their past. A society without history would be in similar condition. It is difficult to understand problems that face in humanity and society today without tracing their origins in the past. Therefore, history is a necessity and it is historians that impose order, pattern, define relationships, giving form and shape to the past.

It is commonly acknowledged that an understanding of the past is fundamental to an understanding of the present. The analysis and interpretation of history provide an essential context of evaluating contemporary institutions, politics and cultures. History also provides unique insight into human nature and human civilization. History can also help us develop tolerance and open-mindedness, and rid ourselves of some of our inherent cultural provincialism. It is also known that historical knowledge is extremely

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Finally, history gives pleasure. This is why history is popular with the public and why many of us find ourselves happy in the fields of history education. History supplies us an endless source of fascination. It combines the excitement of exploration and discovery with the sense of reward born of successfully confronting and making sense of complex and challenging problems.

In summary, history:

- Helps us understand people and societies
- Helps us understand change and how the society we live in came to be
- Contributes to moral understanding
- Provides identity
- Is essential for good citizenship
- Is useful in the world of work
- Provides instructive examples
- Supports common cultural understanding and dialogue

Nevertheless, just as history can be useful, it can also be abused. Such abuses come mainly from the deliberate manipulation of the past to fit a current political agenda. In such cases, history is written backwards. That is, the past is described and interpreted to justify the present. In this regard, a historian is different from the propagandist in that the former takes care to document his judgment and assertions so that they can be subjected to independent and external verification.

HISTORIOGRAPHY

Historiography is the study and writing of history. The desire to record the past is as old as human civilization. This is because humanity has always been interested in its past. But the organized study of the past emerged largely with the rise of civilization.

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Historiography passed through stages of evolution. The first was the period until about the 19th C when the dominant tradition was to regard history as a branch of literature. Though historians emerged with ancient civilization, much is not known about the histories of ancient Mesopotamia and Egypt. However, the world is still captivated by the writings of the Greek historians, such as Homer, Herodotus and Thucydides. Greek Herodotus is generally regarded as the father of history. Herodotus who lived in the 400's BC was the first Greek historian. He recorded the wars between the Greeks and Persians. Herodotus is therefore, called the father of history.

During the medieval period, writers were not critical in their writing. In this period there was decline of historical tradition. History lost its secularity since religion was dominant. Then came the period of renaissance. Here, writers turned to the classical (ancient) writers. They began to promote rational and secular approach to historical writing. They were stimulated by geographical explorations and discoveries. Geographical discoveries demanded reliable information and examination of works. The invention of printing press created a new emphasis on communication and hence on history.

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But, the scientific study of the past (i.e., history as a discipline) took a long time for development. It began to develop only in the nineteenth century. The German historian, Leopold Von Ranke, made the most significant contribution to the development of modern historiography. He began the modern historical methodology, used now by historians. The principle of documentation or the substantiation of statements which is an

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essential component of the historical discipline is one of his greatest legacies. Ranke is, therefore, known as the father of modern history.

1.6.1 THE DEVELOPMENT OF ETHIOPIAN

HISTORIOGRAPHY

A distinctive feature of the Ethiopian past vis-à-vis much of the rest of Africa has been the presence of an indigenous tradition of history writing from at least the fourteenth century to the twentieth. This has been two kinds: the chronicles covering the reign of individual kings and the accounts of longer time spans known as ቅታ፤ ሽሃፍ (history of kings). Although chronicles have a strong chronological framework, they have political and religious bias. They have supernatural explanation for historical phenomenon. The writers of chronicles were called chroniclers. Chroniclers were people who had been assigned by kings to record what they did. Chroniclers were churchmen because they were the only people who could read and write. The first chronicle was the chronicle of Amde- Tsiyon (r. 1314-1344). The emperor was highly concerned that the history of his country should be recorded and thus he appointed special men known as *Tsehafe Tezaz* (chronicler) to study and write the history of the emperors with emphasis on his own time. Though the earliest chronicle known was composed in the 14th C, their content goes a remote past in order to prove the historical genealogical continuity of the emperor for the purpose of political stability and personal existence of the emperor. All chronicles from Amde- Tsiyon to Emperor Tewodros were written in Geez.

Read the following source material. It is an early Amharic poem in praise of Amde- Tsiyon.

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U” k[ᄁ u”c”::	Ÿs ¹ U ¶” ᄁU”::
ŸvK? ›K=”::	ŸÒóf ›”LV”::
ŸÅ ^a a %@Å^”::	uÇVf Vf KT>”::
ŸðÖÖ` ²?L`É”::	T” k[ᄁ u”c”::
Ÿ?óf ›UuM›xj`”::	ÁLeçóᄁ” < Mĩ Ui~”
ŸÓÉU ¾@dÃ”::	N`u— ¯UÅ ê¿”::
Ÿ›”Ô` ¹” ›V^”::	SLLg ¾”c”::

The Modern Chroniclers:- In the nineteenth century, the first Amharic chronicle about emperor Tewodros (1855-1868) was written by Aleqa Zeneb who was the court chronicler of the emperor. He had greater freedom to express independent views. His chronicle didn't exaggerate events.

In the past only one chronicler was assigned to write to history of a certain king. But in 19th C the writing of chronicles were not reserved only for one royal chronicler. Individuals began to write history on their own initiative. This was because the *Zemene Mesafint* had undermined the power of kings. Thus for the first time, we have three chroniclers for one king (Tewodros). These were:

1. Aleqa Zeneb- the court chronicler
2. Aleqa Wolde- maryam- was not court chronicler
3. The author of the third chronicle is anonymous

The chronicle of Emperors Tekle-Giyorgis and Yohanis IV were composed in Geez. The chronicler was Aleqa Lemlem. Emperor Menilek had also his court chronicler. He was *Tsehafe Tezaz* Gebre-Selassie. He composed it in Amharic.

In the early twentieth century, a number of Ethiopian intellectuals write on various aspects of their country's past .Of these, the most notable ones are. Aleqa Taye Gebre-Maryam, Aleqa Atseme-Giyorgis, Blattengeta Heruy Welde-Sellase, Negadras Afework Gebre-Iyesus and Negadras Gebre-Hywot Baykedagn. After 1941, they were followed by Tekle-Tsadeq Mekurya who has written a number of books covering the whole span of Ethiopian history from Aksum to the twentieth century. He represented a bridge between the early pioneers and the more recent practitioners of the discipline.

So far, we have seen the contribution of chroniclers and writers to the development of historical writing. The other contribution was made by European travelers and missionaries. In 1520, a group of Portuguese envoys came to Ethiopia. One of them was a catholic priest called Fransisco Alvarez who wrote a highly informative book about Ethiopia. Then the Jesuits (catholic missionaries) who came to Ethiopia between 1557 and 1632 wrote several books on Ethiopia. Then, throughout the nineteenth century, European travelers, missionaries, explorers, envoys and consuls produced a number of books on Ethiopia. All these works played a considerable role in the development of Ethiopian historiography.

Ethiopian studies as a discipline was founded in Europe in the 17th C. The man who started this task was Job Ludolf who was a German. He was the first European to study Ethiopian history. In 19th C August Dillman published two studies on ancient Ethiopia. If Ludolf is the founder of Ethiopian studies in general, Dillman is the founder of scientific Ethiopian studies in Europe because he is objective and authoritative historian.

TECHNICALITIES ON HISTORICAL WRITING AND RESEARCHING

1 . ARCHIVAL SOURCES

They are primary sources. They are important in carrying out primary research. Archives are documents that are found in government and private organizations arranged systematically with some mechanisms. Because of time and change of governments, archives became dead files fro contemporaries (present time). In Ethiopia, there is no an organized national achieve. Nearly all achieves had been destroyed during the 1974-75 upheavals or in pre-1991-92 civil wars. In the province of Gojjam, for example, all imperial achieves (before 1966 E.C) had been destroyed except in Bichena and Debre Markos towns. The department of history of Bahir Dar University has planed to open Archive and Manuscript unit in the university by gathering archival materials of the Amhara region. If successful, students and researchers of history will be beneficial for their historical research of pre-revolutionary Ethiopia. All achieves can not be kept

through out time. Selection is important. Those archives which have historical values would only be kept for the future others will be destroyed. In the archives we have usually letters, minutes of meetings, resolutions and all of them are primary sources. Because they are produced in a day to day running of a government. Otherwise, they are not produced for influencing history in a certain direction. In Ethiopia, archives can be obtained in two ways:

3. Foreign archives (in abroad)
4. local archives (in Ethiopia)

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There is an organized archives dealing with Ethiopia in a broad. But nationally, there is no organized archives that boasts historical writing. Though the country is rich with centuries of old literate culture, there is no a central depository of written material. This made researchers to depend on the good will of archivists (Paris, London and Rome in particular) or to rely on oral informants.

On the other hand, however, the ex-colonies (Sudan, Kenya, etc) by virtue of their colonial rule, have an organized national archive. In Ethiopia also an attempt to organize a national archive is started. Some years before a law has been declared to establish a national archive and a building for depositing the archives is started. This is a good attempt for the development of Ethiopian historiography.

HOW DO WE WORK IN ARCHIVES?

In archives, we are communicating with dead files. This, is labourious work. This is because, unlike books, archival materials are not produced in a way to facilitate our research activities. Rather, they are produced for their own specific purposes of the period. Archives are also rich with materials you do not want. Thus, one should be able to select the necessary from the unnecessary one. The work will be more difficult and time consuming because most of dead files, in Ethiopia, have been dumped disorderly in underground of a building. So we have to consume much time to go through them. To

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day, in addition to some former woreda or awraja or provincial archives, we find archives on land and related issue in the Welde-Meskel research center in the Institute of Ethiopia studies of Addis Ababa University. We can also find precious archival materials in private hands and in IES manuscript section. In IES, we can obtain all the reports of the emperors since 19th c down to 1945, mostly in micro films.

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The last phase of your work in will be documentation. In books the principles are author title, place of publication, year and page. Example; Richard parkhurst. *Economic History of Ethiopia* (Addis Ababa, 1986), P. 40. Coming to archival materials, however, thins are different and difficult. This is because sometimes we can not find dates and other relevant information. As a result, there is no single rule of documentation. As a general system, use the following method of documentation.

Step One: Write the box title and number of the archive

Step Two: Write the file number

Step Three: Write the year the tile was generated.

Therefore, a researcher who uses the Institute of Ethiopia studies (in the Welde-Mesqel Research center), may write the following note to show the source for the reader of his work.

- **IES/WMRC/ 2266/ 0200/ 1936**, that is,
 - **IES/WMRC** refers the name of the research center
 - **2266** ⇒ Shows box number />nò lØ` /
 - **2200** ⇒ Shows file number
 - **1936** ⇒ Shows the year the file generated or produced.

In Ehtiopia most of the archival materials have been destroyed in 1974 and 1991 upheavals. There is no tradition of keeping such sources for future generation .

2. METHODS IN COLLECTING ORAL SOURCES

As we have mentioned above, oral information and tradition are among the types of sources for historical writing.

Such sources can be obtained through interview. There are ways of approaching and interviewing of an informant. These are:

- 1) Before starting oral research or before starting interviewing we have to be acquainted with the literature on the subject. That is, we have to read secondary written materials. In historical research, questionnaires are not recommended unless for some economic issues like crop production, etc.
- 2) **Identification of Informants;** once we have read secondary materials on the subject, we have to list down informants. One informant may lead us to the other. The literate informants have the weakest power of memories. The illiterate however have no any choice except to remember. Therefore, we have to be careful in selecting informants.
- 3) **Interviewing an Informant:** Here try to create the right kind of atmosphere, approach positively you have to make some sacrifices to invite the informants and make them feel that you are part of them. For example, try to drink what the community drink and eat what they eat. While you sit down to start the interview, allow your informants to relax and chat. It is little by little that you will bring them to your issues. Try to find and select important points from the huge information that your informant is talking about. Otherwise, do not immediately say “I have one question”. Avoid leading questions. Never stop your informant in the course of dialogue. Do not show any impression that you know the subject or an event. If so, the informant may lose his confidence. Rather, allow him to feel as the master on the subject. If he is far from the issue, you have to make intervention and guide him.

Interview may be group interview or individual interview. But individual interview is more important because the informant feels and assumes himself that he is at the top of history. Thus he will clearly and freely narrates the topic. Group interview has its own advantage and disadvantage. The advantage is that you can make cross-checking on the spot and thus save a lot of time. The disadvantage is that it affects the moral of some

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informants in the course of discussion. For examples, if you take a group interview where there are a humble (low origin) peasants and a *grazmach*, the peasants because of their low social status, though knowledgeable on the subject, may keep quiet. Therefore, it is better to avoid group interview men having wide difference of status. If they are peer group, it would be lovely and attractive interview. Moreover, you have to have detail bibliographical information about your informants. This information will be stated in table form at the end of your work. The bibliography should include age, title, place and date of interview.

In taking notes, you may use tape recorder or special cards or writing pad. You can use tape recorder upon permission of the informant. After gathering information, the verification process will follow. That is, the checking and cross-checking of the large information you have collected. There are two ways of cross-checking.

- 1) Checking of one oral testimonies by another oral testimonies
- 2) Testing oral information with written sources. Written sources can give you solution to your problem in oral investigation. Here, it is important to mention that written sources may give us an absolute chronology (exact date) while oral information has a relative chronology. For instance, if an informant says “Tǎŭ” < u}²S} >Uef >Sf qǎ,, }“KÉŸ<,” he was born in 1940 because Maychew campaign was in 1935.

The last phase of your research work will be documentation. Here, there are differences in the process of documentation from that of archival materials. In the footnote, you do not need to give information. You simply write the name of the informant. In the bibliography part, however, you need to have four items for detailed information. These are

- A) Name with the title like *Grazmach*. The name of should be listed alphabetically.
- B) Date and place of interview. This will be an additional information about the informants proximity to the event
- C) Age. In an interview, age is important
- D) The Remarks. This refers the credentials or qualifications of the informant on that particular event. This is very important to identify the informant and his association with the subject.

FOOT NOTE AND BIBLIOGRAPHY

1. FOOT NOTE

In any historical writing or research, all sources should be duly acknowledged. This can be done either by inserting in the text like, for example, (Bahru, 1996: P. 8) or foot noting system. Some writers use both systems together. But instead of using both, use one of them. For historical research foot noting system is more favourable and important. In note writing, consider the following examples :

1. PUBLISHED MATERIALS

A .For a book with more than two authors, use “etal” which means “and others”

This will be done by mentioning the name of the first authour. If they are two, write both.

Example:-

1. John Markakis and Nega Ayele , *Class and Revolution in Ethiopia* (Nottingham: spokesman, 1978),p.8
2. Tadesse Beyene, etal., Title (Oxford: Clarendon press, 1974), PP. 210-12

N.B : . Both Ethiopian and non-Ethiopia names can not be inverted in the case of foot notes

- . In bibliographical writing non-Ethiopians should be inverted.
- . If the source is taken from more than a page, write two P's, i.e., PP.
- . The title of the book should always be either underlined or italicized.
- . Place and date of publication and name of the publisher should be under parenthesis. In case of bibliography, no need of parenthesis
- . Between the name of the author and the title there should be comma. In the case of bibliography it should be a period.

3. UNPUBLISHED MATERIALS

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Example: Temesgen Gebeyehu “ A History of Peasant Resistance Against the Ethiopian Revolution: The Case of Gojjam, 1975-78”, (M.A. Thesis, School of Graduate Studies, AAU, 2005), P. 62

NB: For unpublished materials, the title will be under quotation mark

4. Articles in periodicals

Example: Tadesse Tamirat, “ Ethnic Integration and Interaction in Ethiopian. History: The case of the Agaw,” in *Journal of African Studies* (London: Routledge, 1988), P.10

NB. 1. The article is under quotation mark

2. Name of the periodical is underlined or italicized.

4 . When the author is an editor

Example: Taddesse Beyene, etal (ed), *Kassa and Kassa* (Addis Ababa: AAU, 1990), P 25

5. When your sources are informants

In the footnotes, write only the name of the informant (s) without adding any information. Detail information about your informant will be written in the bibliography part under the heading ‘ List of Informants’.

Example: Informants: Alemayehu Kassa, Mulatu Melesse,

NB. In substantiating each idea, use more than one informant

4. For Archival Sources

See the explanation given above .

2. BIBLIOGRAPHY

A. For Books

Example: Kiflu Taddesse. *Ya Tewelled* (The Generation). part I. NP: Independent publishers, 1983

N.B

- * Use full stop instead of comma between the author and the title
- * No use of parenthesis
- * If place of publication is not mentioned write “NP”
- * If title is written in Amhari, translate it. The translation will be put in parenthesis.

* Space of five letters will be indented in the case of two or more line. In case of foot note writing, the opposite will be happened.

A. For Chapters in Books

Example: Shiferaw Bekele “The Evolution of land Tenure in the Imperial Era,” in Shiferaw Bekele (ed.), *An Economic History of Ethiopia*. Dakar CODESRIA, 1995

D. PUNCTUATIONS

In both foot notes and bibliography punctuations should be written and placed correctly . Look at the following.

1 .Punctuations for books (in a bibliography)

Markakis , John and Nega Ayele . *Class and Revolution in Ethiopia* . Nothingham : Spokesman , 1978 .

2. Punctuations for chapters in a books or articles (in a bibliography)

Ahmed Hassen Omer. “Close Yet Far: Northern Sawa under the *Därg*.” In Wendy James, *et al (eds.) Remapping Ethiopia: Socialism and after* . Oxford: James Currey Ltd, 2002.

3. Punctuations for unpublished materials (in bibliography)

Temesgen Gebeyehu. “ A History of the 1968/9 Peasant Uprising in Eastern Gojjam with Reference to Mota and Bichena” . BA thesis, Baher Dar University, June 2001.

4. Punctuations for unpublished materials (in notes)

Temesgen Gebeyehu, “ A History of the 1968/9 Peasant Uprising in Eastern Gojjam with Reference to Mota and Bichena” (BA thesis, Baher Dar University, June 2001) , p. 2.

4. Punctuations for books (in notes)

John Markakis and Nega Ayele , *Class and Revolution in Ethiopia* (Nothingham : Spokesman , 1978) , p. 2.

In conclusion, please read the following paragraphs given below . Please give attention to the technicalities, not the contents. That is, foot notes (notes) and bibliography.

SUMMARY

History is the study of human past .The human past can be divided into pre-history and history .In study of history, we use periodization, i.e., ancient, medieval and modern. To study history we use sources. Sources form a bridge between the past and the present (the

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historian). Sources can be divided into secondary and primary. History has a number of uses. History meets the needs of the society. The writing and study of history is called historiography. Herodotus is the father of history. But history as a discipline developed in the twentieth century by Leopold Von Ranke. Thus he is described as the father of modern historiography. In Ethiopia an indigenous tradition of history writing has long history

UNIT 2

PHYSICAL AND CULTURAL CONTEXT

CONTENTS

A. GEOGRAPHICAL SETTING

In the study of history, geography has important contributions. The Horn in particular is the region where the physical and human resources form significant impact on the historical processes. It is geographical factors that have determined the rise and consolidation of states they nature and duration of military campaigns, and the patterns of human settlement. It is therefore important to indicate the geographical setting within which the history of Ethiopia and the Horn evolved.

“Ethiopia and the Horn” refers the Northeast Africa that forms the modern states of Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia and Somalia. The Horn is a region of considerable

geographical, linguistic and cultural diversity. It is also the region that has witnessed considerable interaction over a long period of time. The following are important geographical features that have had significant impact on its historical evolution.

Focus

“Ethiopia and the Horn” refers to Northeast Africa that forms the modern states of Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia and Somalia. The Horn is a region of considerable geographical, linguistic and cultural diversity. It is also the region that has witnessed considerable interaction over a long period of time.

1. **The Nile Valley-** It has served as a line of communication and thereby gave rise to some important civilizations, particularly that of ancient Egypt.
2. **The Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden.** They have linked Northeast Africa to the eastern Mediterranean, the near and middle east India, and the Far East, since time immemorial.
3. **The Indian ocean.** Similarly, it has linked East Africa to the Near and Middle East, India and the Far East.

DRAINAGE SYSTEMS

Rivers and the drainage systems provide people with their livelihood and lines of interconnection. People who live within the same drainage system develop interdependence and mutual exchange of ideas, beliefs and other cultural forms. The Horn is the source of five major drainage systems. These are:

- ❖ **The Nile River system:-** It covers the whole of the western part of the region. It extends from Uganda in the South to Egypt in the North.
- ❖ **The Awash Valley:-** It is entirely an Ethiopia system. It links the highlands of central Ethiopia with the hot, dry lowlands of the Danakil Depression.
- ❖ **The Gibe/ Gojeb River system.** This connects the rich areas of Southern Ethiopia to the Semi-desert lowlands of northern Kenya.
- ❖ **The Genale/Juba- Shebele system:-** It covers the rich highlands of Arsi, Bali and Sidamo, and the very hot lowlands of the Somali coast.
- ❖ **The Ethiopian Rift Valley Lakes system:-** This area is characterized by the presence of numerous lakes stretching from Lake Ziway in the north to Lake Turkana (formerly known as Rudolf) on the Ethio-Kenya border.

ENVIRONMENTAL ZONES

This refers the economic formation and settlement pattern of the people. The whole region can be seen as constituting three major environmental zones that run from north to south. These were:

1. The hot lowland region along the Red Sea coast. It starts in a narrow coastal strip in the northeast tip of Eritrea. It gradually widens southwards. It includes the Sahel (lowland Eritrea), the Danakil Depression, the lower Awash Valley and the Republic of Djibouti. It then extends to the Ogaden, the lower parts of Harar, Bale and Sidamo and the whole territory of Somalia. This region is sparsely populated area. Pastoral economy has characterized the region since early times.

2. The Highland massifs. This is just immediately to the west of the hot and lowland region along the red sea coast. It starts from northern Eritrea and continues all the way to southern Ethiopia. It is divided by the rift valley in the east and the west. Its major part is west of the rift valley system. The eastern extension consists of the Arsi, Bali and Harar plateau. It is the region characterized by a terrain combining high mountains and deep valleys and plateaus. The plateaus sustained prosperous economy based on plow agriculture for over the centuries since early times. It inhabits the largest section of the population of the region. It was also here that some of the most important processes of state formation took place in the past.

3. Hot lowland region west of the highland Massifs. It stretches from north to South along the western foothill of the highlands. In earlier times, this region was characterized by thick forests, particularly on the banks of the Nile and its tributaries. The people in this zone have practiced different forms of earning their livelihood, ranging from hunting and gathering, through pastoralist, to shifting cultivation. Shifting agriculture is a type of economic activity that involves moving from plot to plot after each harvest.

In summary, in spite of the diversity described above, there has also been a great deal of interactions among the people, inhabiting different environment zones. For example, people of the plain have interacted with those of the plateau, just as lowlanders have had dealings with highlanders Therefore, the history of Ethiopia and the Horn is essentially

the story of this interaction and interdependence in the economic, social, cultural and political spheres.

B. HUMAN EVOLUTION

Before we directly go to the Evolution of human being, it is better to introduce what evolution is. Evolution is the process by which human as well as living organisms descended from previous organisms with some modification. It is descent with modification.

With regard to the origin of human beings, there are two theories suggested. These are the creationist and evolutionist theory. Those who believe in the assumption that God creates humans and the whole universe are creationists. The evolutionists believe that human beings and other living things are the result of a gradual development that took millions of years.

Focus

With regard to the origin of human beings, there are two theories suggested. These are the creationist and evolutionist theory. Those who believe in the assumption that God creates humans and the whole universe are creationists. The evolutionists believe that human beings and other living things are the result of a gradual development that took millions of years.

Human evolution is the theory, which states that humans evolved from primates, or ape-like, ancestors. Since humans made changes in his physical appearance as well as in his cultural aspects, the study on human evolution focuses on documenting and understanding human biological and cultural changes taking through time.

The biological evolution of human being involves the changes, modification and variations humans experienced all the way from the earliest replicating molecules. It describes the changes that occur in their biological components.

The cultural evolution of human being refers to non-genetic or cultural component of variation and long-term changes accompanying it. During the biological evolution, human beings possess unusual capability for adaptation through learning, experience and use of tools known as culture. Culture thus enables to modify and enhance human behavior without a corresponding change in human genetic composition.

The prehistoric record of our species and its immediate ancestors is characterized by both biological and cultural evolution. However, biological rather than cultural changes dominated the first several million years of our existence.

The evolution of our earliest ancestors is highlighted by key changes in upright walking system, teeth (dentition), and the size and organization of the brain.

The biological evolution of human's ancestors is assumed to have occurred since about 8 million to 4 million years ago. In short, it is during this time range that the human group (lineage) is assumed to have sprung from other primates or apelike creatures.

The first recorded evidence on the cultural evolution however is considered to have its beginnings since around 2.6 million years ago. Yet, compared to the biological changes, humans made dramatic advances of transformation in culture since the last hundred thousand years.

Now let us briefly examine evidence of human evolution. As mentioned above, around the 8 million to 4 millions years ago, the human branch had diverged into single line of descent. According to the evolutionists, human beings and apes (Chimpanzees, gorillas, orangutans) had a common ancestor. However, through time, these organisms passed through a separate course of gradual development. According to researchers the human group, like other animals belong to the order primates. Nevertheless, in its family, the human group belongs to Hominoidea. The Hominoids refers to groups of all present and past apes as well as humans. The hominid on the other hand is restricted specifically to present and past human group. Hominid is, therefore, means man like beings. The gradual development in the hominid species finally gave rise to the emergence of modern humans.

Climatic and environmental changes activated by natural selection taking place across time helped the evolution of primates in general and the hominids in particular. As existing study indicates, the early members of our lineage-hominid had appeared in East Africa

HOMINID SPECIES IN ETHIOPIA

Before go to the discussion, it is important to say that:

- The first serious attempt to conduct archaeological excavation in Ethiopia was made by the German expedition of 1906, which surveyed northern Ethiopia and stayed at Aksum for several weeks.
- The Ethiopian institute of Archeology was established in 1952 and it began to coordinate archaeological excavations conducted in the country since then.

Although archeological studies in Ethiopia produced a number of material remains from different parts, I would like to draw your attention only to findings that deal with human evolution. It is also important to indicate the role of the East African region (Kenya, Tanzania) particularly the rift valley areas, as source of fossil evidences. Therefore, due to:

- The longest known record of occupation by hominids and their closer relatives,
- The biogeographical zone East Africa lies
- Earth moments associated with the rift valleys that created sedimentary basins in which fossils and archeological sites could be preserved with a minimum of disturbance, and
- The continued volcanic activity that provides a basis for K-A dating and geophysical chronology, East Africa has become pre-eminent in the study of early man.

In this region, evidences on successive human species have been discovered. In general, different species of the genus *Australopithecus* and *Homo* are evidenced from this part of Africa.

In Ethiopia, paleo- anthropologists obtained different remain (fossil evidences) of human being. In the excavations and discoveries held in 1974 at Hadar Ethiopia, fossil remain estimated at age of 3.18 million years was discovered by Donald Johanson.

The finding is named as Lucy or Dinqnesh. It almost has a complete skeleton of a female hominid remain with 40% of her skeleton being preserved. Portions of both legs, including a complete right knee joint, her pelvis, the upper leg bone an tibia (showing her to have been bipedal) were discovered. In addition to this extra ordinarily complete fossil

remain from Afar, the first family remain is also obtained from Afar. Here about 13 individuals' remains were discovered.

Lucy belongs to the oldest hominid species called *Australopithecus afarensis*. *Australopithecus* is the name given to age-like hominid creatures while the word *afarensis* is derived from Afar where the fossil is discovered.

From the Afar region, other fossil evidence was discovered in 1994. At a locality called Aramis, fossils from 17 individuals dated to an estimated age of 4.4 millions years were discovered. The finding is named *Australopithecus ramidus*. *Ramidus* is adapted from the site name. Other species of *Australopithecus* is also discovered from Afar region of Ethiopia.

In general, *Australopithecus* species over bipedal and its dentition appears more human like than age-like. Their brains tend to be slightly larger than those of the greater apes are. They also have smaller cranium, relatively large lower face and small front teeth than the back teeth. Nevertheless, *Australopithecus* is clearly Hominid.

In addition to the *Australopithecine* species, paleo-anthropologists have unearthed other hominid species. The species discovered have larger brain, smaller tooth, thin face and a high cranium with the ability to use tool. These fossil evidences belong to a new genus of hominid called *Homo*.

The earliest of such species discovered from East African in general and Ethiopian in partial is *Homo habilis*, which means "handy man". One of the distinguishing characters of *Homo habilis* is the ability to make tools. The earliest evidence of tool making came from Gona area from Afar dated to 2.6 million years old. In terms of temporal and spatial distribution, the *Homo habilis* findings apparently range from about 2.4 million to 1.5 millions years old. With the existing evidence, remains of *Homo habilis* are found only from East Africa.

By 2.4 million years ago, the early *Homo* became clearly established human group as a lineage separate from that of the later forms of *Australopithecus*. The *Australopithecus*

afarensis was ancestral to the Homo. The change in dietary specialization for hard objects and rough vegetation led to the divergence of human evolution. One branch thus led to the emergence of the genus Homo.

Some time around 1.8 million to 300,000 years ago, a much better known and larger-brained member of the genus, Homo erectus roamed over much of the old world. The most notable, physical change to occur within the genus is in the brain size and organization. Homo erectus is taller, larger-brained, and more culturally complex. It evolved out of an African population of early Homo, and then migrated across the old world.

Fossil remains of Homo erectus are discovered from South East Asia, China, Germany, Hungary, Spain and Africa.

Homo erectus appears to be both physically and culturally intermediate between earlier and later forms of humans. It has larger brain than the early Homo but shorter and smaller-brained than the Homo sapiens. The Archaeological finds associated with Homo erectus reflect a trend towards cultural complexity with more diversified lifestyle. It has demonstrated the controlled use of fire. Earlier hominids were confined to Africa only but Homo erectus migrated out of Africa. It thus is marked by great expansion in both time and space.

By about 300,000 years ago, Homo erectus began to disappear from the fossil record. Over the past 500,000 to 200,000 years, another species, Homo sapiens started to evolve out of some population or populations of Homo erectus. By 200,000, Homo erectus had disappeared and Homo sapiens had become firmly established species.

Homo sapiens differ from Homo erectus in their

1. Larger brain, a more round and vaulted skull and a more delicate facial structure than Homo erectus
2. Jaws and teeth are relatively small

There are three stages through which the Homo species passed before the emergence of modern humans. These are :

- Homo habilis – i.e. able to make simple tools
- Homo erectus- i.e. able to erect upright and walk

- Homo Sapiens- i.e. Knowledge is the distinctive feature of modern human.

Ethiopia offers fossil evidences of these human species as well. For instance, the remains of the Homo habilis were found in the lower Omo valley. The remains of Homo erectus were discovered at MelkaKunture, in Konso-Gardula and in the lower Omo valley. Remains of Homo sapiens were discovered at Bodo (middle Awash, Kibish(lower Omo), and porc epic (near Dire Dawa). Recently (2003) three new skulls from Herto (form Afar region) dated at 160,000 years were discovered. They are the oldest known modern human fossils. The discoveries are assigned them to a new sub species, Homo sapiens idaltu. It is said that this remain is an atomically and chronological intermediate between older archaic humans and more recent fully modern humans.

In general, fossils and artifacts are discovered from the middle Awash, Hadar, Dikaka, Gona, and Konso. They represent some of the most spectacular hominid specimens ever found on this planet. The age and anatomy of this species is cited as strong evidence for the emergence of modern humans from Africa, and against the multi regional theory, which argues that modern humans evolved in many places around the world.

UNIT 3

LANGUAGES OF ETHIOPIA

3.1 Classification of Ethiopian Languages

As we have already mentioned in the previous section, humans made cultural evolution. One component of cultural evolution is the development of communication means. It is through communication that individual members of a society could learn about their culture and pass on its adaptive strategies to future generations.

In short, hominid adaptation includes increased intelligence and symbolic thought that are the basis of much of human communication. Information exchange is a highly elaborated feature of the human adaptive strategy; without it, especially without language, culture would not exist. Language is thus the single most important element to understand human culture. It also evolves with the evolution and development of human species.

Language as it evolves may also become extinct through different reasons. For instance due to subjugation of people through conquest or other forms of forced change, language may cease to be spoken. Hence, linguistic extinction does not necessarily mean that the society or people who originally spoke the language have ceased to exist. Through linguistic multiplication, differentiation within a language-variant form may occur. Since language derived from a common ancestor, related languages are interlinked. Nevertheless, it does not mean that each language has a single line of descent. But each language consists of fundamental inherited core, plus differing degrees of admixture of elements adopted from other languages with which that language has interacted during its history. For linguistic continuity, there may also be broken descent. It may occur due to displacement of the speakers by other dominant groups. The potentialities of using adopted or borrowed elements as guide to the historical interactions between societies have for the most part been used as important linguistic evidences. Linguistic evidences can help us perceive better how peoples of a region might have evolved over time. It also helps trace contacts and links between different peoples in ancient time.

Although the evolution of language is much earlier, peoples of North East Africa witnessed the presence of a language group called-proto Afro-Asiatic language since ancient times (not less than 15,000 years ago). This language group subsequently differentiated into different divisions.

According to recent findings, the area from the shores of the Red Sea stretching westwards to Lake Nasser on the Nile have in general been considered as place of speakers of this group of language had spread over. It is also assumed that this language group differentiated eventually into various languages and spread to other regions. For

instance, by about 9000 B.C people speaking a language ancestral to the later Semitic languages, moved North ward crossing the Sinai peninsula, and into the Palestine Syria region of far South West Asia. Another language group, Chadic spread in to much part of west and Saharan North Africa. The other group, which is ancestral to Cushites, occupied the area from the southern Red sea hills to Northern fringe of the Ethiopian highlands.

3.2 LANGUAGE FAMILIES IN ETHIOPIA

Ethiopia and the Horn, in general, is marked by ethnic and linguistic diversity. The languages spoken in the region, though varied and many, however, show a considerable interrelationships among themselves.

The language groups currently spoken over the entire Ethiopian region belong to Afro-Asiatic and Nilo-Saharan super families of the earliest African languages.

The Afro Asiatic language group includes the Cushitic, Semitic and the Omotic sub families that dominantly exist over the wide part of Ethiopia today. The Nilo-Sahara group on the other hand covers only the western boarder lands of the country adjoining the Sudan.

Focus

Ethiopia and the Horn, in general, is marked by ethnic and linguistic diversity. The languages spoken in the region, though varied and many, however, show a considerable interrelationships among themselves.

CUSHITIC

This covers the great majority of the region's population and spreads over into such neighboring regions as the Sudan and even as far South as Tanzania.

As mentioned earlier, there was spread of language group from one area to another. Similarly, many of the Cushitic expanded southwards in to the Northern and Northeastern parts of the Ethiopian highlands since the seventh and six millennium B.C. One branch,

the Northern cushiest, controlled and inhabited the Southern Red sea hills. The Beja peoples belong to the later day descendants of this group.

The period from 3500 to 1000 B.C, saw a marked and continued expansion of Cushitic population into the Ethiopian high lands. During this time, the group of Cushitic peoples known as the Agaw, established themselves across large parts of the Northern and North-central high lands. This group now a day is represented by the Belen (Bogos) in Eritrea and by the Agaw in Qwara, Matakka and Agawmeder as well as along both sides of the Takkaze River.

By the time, when one group of the Cushitic spread in to the Northern and North-central parts of the Ethiopian highlands, and other branch (Eastern Cushitic communities) newly expanded their cultivation and herding into a wide range of areas all through the eastern parts of the high lands. They are represented by east high land Cushitic that consisted under it the Hadiya, Kambata, Sidama, Gedeo, Alabal, Burji and Libido groups of people.

As the climate showed marked dried condition, one sub group of the Eastern Cushitic communities whom we call the highland Eastern Cushitic moved into the areas all along the western side of the life. They gradually mixed with the omotic ancestry. One spoke the ancestral highland Eastern Cushitic language while the other spoken an omotic language- omoto and they become omoto- Hametic.

In addition to these groups of the ancient Cushitic expansion, there was movement of Eastern Cushitic in to the plains and grasslands along the rift valley floor and the adjacent areas. This group consisted the low land Cushitic who occupied the vast eastern low lands of the region. The Saho and afar, Oromenna and Somali, represent them.

SEMITIC

We have noticed above that the ancestral language of the Semitic had moved from North East Africa into the Red sea Mediterranean parts of Asian land mass around 9000 B.C.

The Semitic language is the second widely spoken language in the region. Although the greater part of the population of Northern Ethiopia represented by the Cushitic in ancient times, it is now predominantly inhabited by Semitic language speakers. It is probable that these Semitic languages owe their presence in this region as the result of the gradual infiltration of the Northern highlands by agricultural people from South Arabia in the first millennium B.C.

The Semitic language family, like the Cushitic language, is divided into North Ethio-Semitic and South Ethio-Semitic group. Under the North Ethio-Semitic, we found Tegra, Tegrēñña and the ancient language as main branches while with the South Ethio-Semitic, Amharic, Argobba, Gafat, Guragenna, and Harari belonged.

OMOTIC

Omotic language branch refers many of the languages spoken mainly in the Omo valley. In earlier times, however, it had extended much farther to the North. The Southward expansion of Agaw communities might have resulted in the occupation of some areas previously inhabited by Omotic peoples. Over the centuries, the Omotic communities were therefore gradually absorbed into the expanding Agaw societies, until eventually all of the high lands as far south as the Abbai River and as far southwest as the upper Awash River were occupied. Still farther south in the high lands, some of the Omotic encountered and intermixed with the other Cushitic peoples from the East. Currently, this group embraces under it as many as 26 different Omotic languages spoken in Ethiopia to day. The main ones are Gofa, Keffa, Kullo, Gimira, Ari, Sheko, Maji, Walayta, and Gamo.

NILO- SAHARAN

It is one of the main language families spoken particular in the western boulder lands of Ethiopia. Speakers of this language group are thought to have been penetrated to Ethiopia from Sudanese region following the courses of the Nile since the desiccation of the Sahara around third millennium B.C. Anuak, Gumuz, Kunama, Barta, Nuer, Majangir and Mien are included among the lists in this super family of Ethiopian languages.

UNIT 4

ORIGIN OF CLASSES AND STATES

4.1 THE DOMESTICATION OF PLANTS AND ANIMALS

For millions of years, people were entirely dependent on nature. They simply hunted wild animals, gathered fruits, and other plant products. They made, however, simple tools out of stone, bone and wood to ease exploitation of nature. They also used fire for heating purposes as well as for keeping themselves from dangerous animals. Later they began to use it for cooking food.

How and why then people shifted from collection of wild plant and animal products to intentional domestication of plants and animals?

Domestication refers to the process through which humans modify plants and animals to enhance characteristics that human's desire. It is when humans apply this activity that species of animals and plants became domestic and showed differences from their wild counterpart. The long period of gathering and hunting helped people know more about plants and animals. Man thus began to domesticate them instead of moving in search of wild food sources. Why humans began this process is still controversial. No single theory seems to apply to all cases of food production in the world. This is because the evolution of food production appears to have taken widely different paths from one region to another. However, most archaeologists assume that certain conditions must have pushed people to switch from collecting to producing food. Climatic change at the end of last ice age (after about 10,000 B.C), population growth, especially in regions of abundant wild resources and the desire to create surpluses of storable or particularly sought-after foods are among the major theories to propose the beginning food production.

It is assumed, under the existing archaeological evidence, that the earliest domesticates of plant are wheat and barely remains obtained specifically from the Levant. The remains are dated at 10,500 B.P. Sheep and goats were domesticated somewhat later, perhaps 9000 B.P.

In Africa, recent studies of cattle genetics have demonstrated that several African groups independently domesticate cattle perhaps as early as 9,000 B.P. Although earlier studies

attribute plant domestication in Africa to about 4000 and 6000 years ago, archaeologists indicate in their recent studies that Sorghum appears to have been an early domesticate. The evidence of early Sorghum domesticate dated to about 8000 B.P is obtained from the early Khartoum tradition.

In Ethiopia, due to the limited archaeological research, it is difficult to give clear picture on the beginning of domestication of plants and animals in the region. Nevertheless, archaeologists and Paleobotanits still argue that Ethiopia in particular and North East Africa in general is one important center of early plant domestication. This is because Ethiopia provided indigenous groups both cereals and non-cereals. These include crops like teff, dagussa, nug, enset, coffee and even chatt. Linguistic archaeologists also argue that ancient cughitic peoples of the region might have cultivated such crops. They estimate this activity as far back as to the seventh millennium B.C. The use of Cushitic terms for some objects like the plow might also be an indication for an indigenous beginning agriculture.

Focus

In Ethiopia, due to the limited archaeological research, it is difficult to give clear picture on the beginning of domestication of plants and animals in the region. Nevertheless, archaeologists and Paleobotanits still argue that Ethiopia in particular and North East Africa in general is one important center of early plant domestication.

Some researchers also argue that the later prehistory of Ethiopia offers several important contrasts with that of other African regions, both in the emphasis of the research so far conducted and in the results obtained. Environmental archeologists on the other hand view Ethiopia as being characterized by great contrasts both in the physical isolation and in environmental varieties. With these and other background, researchers pre suppose that the history of Ethiopian agriculture must be much earlier than expected now. The fact that Ethiopia bears a wide variety of both non-cereal and cereal crops made it to be recognized as one center of indigenous plant domestication.

However, this does not mean that Ethiopia did not introduced Middle Eastern cereal complex. Wheat and barley brought in from the Middle East via Egypt. There are also controversies on the origin of domestication of Barely. Ethiopia is target as one possible place of Origin for the barley crop. In order to, under stand the Neolithic development in Ethiopia, more archaeological endeavor is required essentially.

Although archaeological evidence on the beginning of those development (plant and animal domestication) in Ethiopia still in sufficient, few sites provided evidences on the early domestication of plants and animals.

The archaeological excavation from Gobedra rock shelter (near Aksum) has produce early Holocene microlithic industries, pottery dated to fourth or third millennium B.C. , remains of camel tooth and fingers millet (dated to 3rd millennium B.C). More over, there are sites such as lalibella & Natchibet caves near Lake Tana Gondar that provided crop remains, stone tools and ceramic fragments. Nevertheless, crop remains obtained are related to the Middle Eastern cereal assemblage. The rift valley region and the rock shelter of laga oda near Harar, Gurgussom in the Danakil, the Temben area in Tigray, quiha in Tigray Gorgora, and Lake Basaqa near matara are archaeological sites that provided remains related to plant and animal domestication Ethiopia. . Rock paintings from Northern Ethiopia (Eritrea, Tigray), South Eastern and Southern Ethiopia are indicators of such activities. There are paintings of cattle, sheep, goat, camel ana other human and geomorphic pictures that serve as an important sources of evidence on domestication activity as well as the artistic development of ancient peoples of the region.

It is important to note that though these cereals are independently unique to Ethiopia, we have no clear picture whether the beginning of domestication in Ethiopia is an in situ, independent (local) or diffused from out side. We vividly lack information when, which and how each element were introduced to Ethiopia. However, it should be assumed that the region could not at any cost be very isolated to the influence of the out side world for that period.

Likewise, security and economic reasons required families to live together. They built their houses and began to work on their farms. With the growth of population, the simple agricultural tools like hoe and stick had to be replaced by the ox-drawn plow.

In short, regardless of why food production originated, it seems to have had important consequences for human life. These include among others:

- Substantial increase in population
- Increased sedentary life with greater reliance on agriculture

- Increased permanent village with more elaborate houses and furnishings
- Differentiations in the acquisition of wealth
- Increased long distance trade due to villages all that led to the emergence of civilization

4.2 CLASS AND STATE FORMATION

With the development of food production, differences in the acquisition of wealth would arise. With population increase and more reliance on agriculture, communities came into existence. There is also increased interaction among societies with increased dimensions of contact. The need for group work (cooperation among people) particularly in situations that require such demands as basic to their survival would likely occur. For example, irrigational and related works could have necessitated such demands.

Under such situations, sharing of various responsibilities by members of a community and the need for arbitration may arise. This in turn might have dictated the beginning of chiefs or headmen among a certain communities. Increased production as well as increased need for improved tools, goods and others may led to the emergence of different classes over time. On the other hand, beliefs in traditional religion gave rise to the emergence of religious leaders.

Until now, no theory seems to fit the entire known situation on why and how states arose. A combination of factors may have fostered the formation of states and classes. The desire to control single most important resources like water and other resources in general, population growth, food production, inter-regional interaction, trade etc are however considered some of the possible factors that contribute to the formation of class and state.

State is polity in which leaders are capable of governing by force. It also implies an ability to organize large populations for a collective purpose. This purpose could be the need to organize trade and other social activities. Nevertheless, these leaders were typically distinguished from others in the society as a separate noble class.

A state has a variety of formal positions through which power is exercised, including the nobility police or military, judges and others. To support the nobility and others working for the state government, a state typically collect tribute or taxes from food producers and artisans. States often developed formal writing systems. State governments are also typically centered in locations where markets, offices, courts and urban and centralized elements or urban polities with a complex bureaucracy and social classes found.

Based on existing archaeological and historical evidences, the earliest states appeared in Mesopotamia. Almost at related time, states arose in ancient Egypt. In both cases around 5000-6000 years ago.

Although state and class formation has such long history in the Middle East and the Nile valley Egypt, we are in a complete shortage of data on the formation of these elements in Ethiopia.

It is assumed that civilizations and states developed in Ethiopia as being attributed to a process of diffusion or migration of such things from out side-particularly with Semitic migration. Moreover, states in southern Ethiopia are regarded to have originated from the Northern half.

There are, however, evidences on the presence hierarchical societies in the region southeast of the Nile valley from fourth to the second millennia B.C. The rise of such states may be attributed to :

- Egyptian commercial activity along the Nile valley and the Red Sea from the fourth to the second millennia B.C.
- Inter regional exchange circuit between the Arabia and the Red Sea world since the seventh millennium B.C.

Still, there are growing emphasis on the presence of indigenous elements, civilizations and states in Ethiopia. The material conditions of society that induces greater social differentiation and more sharply defined division of labour might have led to the genesis of classes and states in Ethiopia. Nevertheless, up on the local basis, there could be definitely external influences.

SUMMARY

Human Evolution is a gradual process through which modern human species evolved. Ethiopia occupies a central place in the study of Human Evolution. Remains of different species of Hominid dated to 5 million years old are discovered. The Afar, Awash and Omo areas of Ethiopia are noted prominently in fossil remains. Study on Ethiopian prehistory particularly the later and the proto-history are still at its stage of infancy.

Cushitic, Semitic, Omotic and Nilo-Saharan are the main language family in Ethiopia. Teff, dagussa nug and enset, coffee ad chatt are native crops to Ethiopia. The root of domestication and state formation in Ethiopia might have an indigenous element. However, there could also be external influence (component) that enhanced it. In 1906, the German expedition visited northern Ethiopia and began an organized excavation. In 1952, the Ethiopian Institute of Archeology was established and it began to coordinate archaeological excavations.

UNIT 5

RELIGION

6.1 INTRODUCTION

Religion is defined as system of beliefs and practices related to the gods/God. It provides a moral standard to be met by all individuals. It connects man and gods/God relationships. According to all religions:

- There is a belief that a person lives only once.
- The material world is seen positively.
- They belief in divine & judgment.

Ethiopia and the Horn has been the home of different religious beliefs and practices from time immemorial. The three major religions, which still claim the allegiance of the region's population, are, in the chronological order in which they appeared, the following.

6.2 TRADITIONAL BELIEFS

Religion is as old as civilization. In the previous chapter, we have studied the origin of agricultural. With the development of agriculture, people came to attribute some natural phenomena like reproduction, growth of animals and plants, change of climate and seasons to super natural forces. As a result, they began to worship various natural objects such as the sky, the moon, the sun, rivers, mountains and trees. In Ethiopia, for example, before the introduction of Christianity, people were worshipping different gods including Greek and south Arabia gods. According to existing evidences, before his conversion to Christianity, king Ezanz was paying tribute to Mahrems (the god of war) and meder (the god of the earth). In one of the inscriptions mentioned above, for instance, he attributed the victory over his enemies to Mahrem and made some offerings to the same god.

In other communities of Ethiopia and the Horn, too, traditional beliefs have been practiced. Among the Oromo, for example, that supernatural power is called Waqa. In these societies, there are people who act as intermediaries or mediators between gods and people. The Oromo call these mediators (priests and priestesses) qallu (for men) and qallitti (for women). The qallu and qallitti interpret the mysteries of nature and care for the spiritual well- being of the community. Since the distinction between the religious

and secular spheres of life was not well defined in traditional societies, the qallu/qallitti exercised considerable influence outside the spiritual sphere in the economic, political and social life of the people.

Similar deities and spirits were and are in some cases still practiced among other southern peoples of the region. The Hadiya had an equivalent to the Oromo Waqa known as the *Wa*, which followed in the hierarchy by spirits who attracted most of the prayers and sacrifices. The Kambata have religious officials known as the Magnancho (“God’s people”). Among the Gurage, too, there have been three major traditional deities. These were the waq (the supreme deity), the Bozha (the god of thunder) and Damwamwit (a goddess with a supernatural healing powers).

An interesting feature of traditional religion is the way in which its practitioners fused it with Christian and Muslim beliefs and practice over time. This phenomenon of the creative mixing of religions is known as syncretism. A typical example of this is the way pre-Christian ceremony celebrating nature was fused with the Christian feast for the finding of the True Cross (Meskel). Likewise, one can see an element of syncretism in fasting practices among the Kambata and Hadiya. Thus, the Muslims fast of Romadon has been superimposed over the pre-Muslim Hadiya practice known as fandano.

6.3 CHRISTIANITY

First, let us see a brief introduction about the origin and expansion of Christianity. The Jews were the first people who began a belief in one God. They called their God Yahweh. Between 8 and 4 B.C, Jesus Christ was born in Palestine. Out of his teaching Christianity was born in the kingdom of Judah, a state ruled by a Jewish Dynasty loyal to the Roman Empire. The new religion came to include the Jewish belief in God. That is why the Old Testament became part of the Bible.

After the crucifixion of Christ, His followers began preaching Christianity and set up the first Christian church. Despite ruthless persecution by the Roman rulers, many people gradually accepted Christianity in the Middle East. Once Christianity became an official religion of the Roman Empire, Rome became to be the seat of the pop, head of all

Christian churches. However, the bishops of the eastern churches of Egypt and Syria resisted the power of the people and they called themselves patriarch which means fatherly governor.

Later differences in interpretation brought about division within the church. For example, in the fourth century A.D. a priest from Alexandria called Arius taught that God the Son could not have exactly the same nature as God the Father. He also believed that Christ, or God the Son must be somehow inferior to God the Father. This teaching known as Arianism brought about the first division of the Christian church. His bitter opponent was Athanasius, the bishop of Alexandria.

In order to bring about unity in the church, Constantine, the first Christian Roman Emperor, held the first council in 325 A.D at Nicaea. Arianism was condemned and the emperor issued a decree in favour of Athanasian doctrine, a belief maintaining that God the Father and God the Son had identical nature.

Again in the fifth century AD, another teaching divided the church. The division was based on the nature of Christ. One group believed that Christ the God and Christ the Man had separate natures. The other group believed that the divine and human nature of Christ were united. This belief in the unity of the two natures was known as monophysitism. In 451 A.D Emperor Marcian summoned a council at Chalcedon, near Constantinople to bring an end to the religious division. The council accepted the belief in the two separate natures of Christ and condemned the monophysite doctrine. As a result, the eastern Orthodox church separated itself from the Roman Catholic Church.

Christianity was first introduced in Aksum in the first half of the 4th century AD by a young Christian from the eastern Mediterranean by the name of Frementos (known as Fremantus to Europeans). The first to accept Christianity was king Ezana who employed Frementos in the royal court. Frementos used that position to convert the king and some members of the nobility to the new religion. For sometime, however, Christianity was limited to the royal family and the nobility. The propagation of Christianity among the mass of the people was to wait until the latter part of the fifth century. At that time some

monks (referred to as the “Nine Saints in Ethiopian Christian tradition) from east Mediterranean. These monks initiated the translation of the Bible and other religious books into Ge’ez, built churches and monasteries such as Debre Damo in northern Tigray. In general, they helped the spread of Christianity among the large sections of the Aksumite population. Moreover, the coming of Frementos and the first Christian missionaries from the eastern Mediterranean region and the appointment of Egyptian bishops led to Ethiopia’s association with the Eastern Orthodox Church.

Focus

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After the fourth century A.D Christianity became the official religion of the Aksumite Empire king. Caleb, for example, reported to have built churches even in South Arabia. Even after the fall of Aksum, Christianity continued to flourish during the Zagwe period. The construction of rock-hewn churches can be taken as a good indication for the devotion of the Zagwe rulers to the expansion of Christianity. During the medieval period the expansion of Christianity gained fresh momentum. Many more monasteries and churches were established in various parts of Ethiopia. Among these are the island monasteries of Lake Hayq, Tana and Ziway; Debre Libanos of shewa ; Debre Bizen of Hamasen (in Eritrea); the great educational centers of Debre Dima and Debre Work in eastern Gojjam; and the monastery of Debre Asebot on the way to Harar. These churches and monasteries are not merely religious centers. They also served through the ages of repositories of the products of Christian culture, ancient Ge’ez manuscripts and precious objects of Christian orthodox. By the sixteenth century, Christianity had expanded into such southern Ethiopian regions as Keffa, Ennerya, Gamo, Welayta, Kambata and Gurage.

The conversion of Aksum to Christianity was the logical outcome of its close links (particularly commercial) with the Greco-Roman world. The introduction of Christianity to Ethiopia (Aksum) has the following consequences. To begin with, after its conversion, Aksum pursued a policy of solidarity leading to alliance with Christian Byzantium in the

international politics of the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean. Secondly, the introduction of Christianity tied the fate of Christian Ethiopia with that of Egypt. Frementos was appointed as the first bishop of the new church of Aksum by patriarch Atnatewos of Alexandria. This had both ideological and administrative implications. Ideologically, the Ethiopian church, like its Egyptian (Coptic) mentor, came to follow the monophysite creed of Christianity. Administratively, the Ethiopian church remained subservient to the Coptic Church in Egypt. full independence (i.e. the consecration of its own patriarch by the Ethiopia church) was achieved only in 1919. Thirdly, the introduction of Christianity brought on interdependence between the church and the state. That is, in christainity, the Ethiopian ruling class came to have a highly developed ideology that legitimized and reinforced its rule. Thus, the Ethiopian Orthodox Church was to play an important role in history as the ideological arm of the state. The king became head not only of the state but also of the church. Both parties benefited from this state of affairs. The church enjoyed royal protection and patronage, ranging in concrete terms from the founding of churches to the granting of land. In return, the church preached the subject's unwavering loyalty to the sovereign.

Focus

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6.4 ISLAM

Mohammed, the founder of Islam was born around 570 A.D in Arabia. When Mohammed began his teaching first to his family and then to the people of Mecca, he faced a strong resistance. At that time, the Arabs were pagans worshipping stones and trees. As a result, the first followers of Mohammed were persecuted. In about 615 A.D Mohammed sent his followers including his daughter and son-in-law to take refuge in Ethiopia. They were allowed to stay in Ethiopia until their return to Arabia in 628A.D.

In 622 AD, Mohammed moved from Mecca to Medina. His journey to Medina is known as Hejira, which is the beginning of the Islamic calendar. Medina became the center of the new religion. Mohammed began a holy war (Jihad) against unbelievers. In 630 A.D he returned to Mecca as conqueror. He removed all the pagan gods except the black

stone, which was incorporated into Islam. At the time of his death in 632, one-third of Arabia had accepted Islam. The Arabs were able to expand Islam outside Arabia. Within a decade after the death of Mohammed, they conquered Egypt, Palestine, Syria and the Persian Empire. Gradually, Islam expanded to North Africa, other parts of the Middle East and in 724, it reached India.

Like the division of the Christian church into eastern orthodox and Roman Catholic, there was division within Islam. The main reason for the division was the question of succession. One group believed that only members of Mohammed's family should be appointed as a caliph (the representative of Mohammed). Those who followed this view were known as Shiites (sectarians). Those who opposed this view were called Sunnites (traditionalists). The Sunnites believed that any eligible person (Muslim) could be elected as a caliph. They also agreed that the Quran (the Holy Book of Muslims) should be supplemented with commentaries called traditions. But the Shiites rejected that. This division led to the establishment of two rival Islamic states. In 660 A.D, Muawiyq, a leader of the Sunnites and a member of the Umayyad family set up the Umayyad Caliphate in Damascus. The Shiites also decided to create their own state. In about 750 A.D; Abbas, the great grandson of a cousin of Mohammed established a rival state known as the Abbasid Caliphate. Baghdad became the center of the Abbasid caliphate. Later separate Muslim states also emerged in Morocco, Tunisia, Egypt and Syria.

Coming to the origin and expansion of Islam in Ethiopia, it was in the eighth century that the first Muslims settled on the Dahlak islands. Later, in the tenth century, they formed their own state (sultanate). That led to the spread of Islam along the Red sea coastal areas. However, Islam remained restricted to the low land areas of northern Ethiopia. This was because Christianity had already been deeply rooted and well established. As a result, there was no room left for the expansion of Islam except the settlement of some Muslim traders along the major trade routes and markets. In any case, however, it was through the Dahlak Islands that Islam entered northern Ethiopia.

The second gateway of Islam was the port of Zeila .Zeila was the main gateway for the penetration of Islam into central and eastern Ethiopia, particularly Harar, Wello and Eastern Shewa. Since Christianity did not yet reach central, eastern and southern Ethiopia Islam came to dominate those areas. The earliest Muslim communities in the region set up their own sultanates. The first Muslim state was the sultanate of Shewa. It emerged in the beginning of the eleventh century. The dynasty that ruled the sultanate was known as the Makhzumite dynasty because the ruling family claimed descent from the Makhzumi clan of Mecca. In the thirteenth century, a man called Umar Wolasma founded his own Sultanate- the sultanate of Ifat. Similarly, other Muslim states emerged between the eleventh and fourteenth centuries. Still, however, in Ethiopia, the process of islamization was not followed by Arabization for the following reasons:

- A. The Ethiopian Muslims retained with their culture and language. That is, the converts remained with their national and ethnic identity.
- B. The Arabs did not carry out any conquest in Ethiopia.
- C. In Ethiopia, there was no large scale Arab migration

Islam and Christianity have coexisted peacefully in the region for many centuries. The conflict of the medieval period between the Christian kingdom and the Muslim states of South Eastern Ethiopia were the only major exception to a record of mutual tolerance. As in case of Christianity, the establishment and growth of Islam contributed to the development and enrichment of the culture of the region. Finally, like churches and monasteries, mosques have been centers of Islamic learning and housed works Islamic art and literature.

Focus

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SUMMARY

Religion is as old as civilization . Ethiopia and the Horn has been the home of different religious beliefs and practices from time immemorial. All in all ,there are three types of religion in Ethiopia and the Horn.. These were traditional, Christianity and Islam.

Traditional religion is the oldest and indigenous to the region. People were worshipping

different gods including the Greek and South Arabian gods. Examples of traditional beliefs in Ethiopia were the Waqa of Oromo, Wa of the Hadiya, and the Magnancha of the Kambata.

Christianity was introduced to Ethiopia in the 4th century from the Middle East by Frementos .The first to accept Christianity was the King Ezana. Yet ,Christianity spread to the masses in the fifth century with the coming of the nine missionaries from Syria. These monks translated the bible into Geez, ,built churches and monasteries.

With regard to Islam ,it was founded by Mohammed in about late 6th century. But in Ethiopia Islam was expanded in the eighth century mainly through trade. It was introduced through two points : Dahlak Islands and Zeila. The latter was the main gate way for the penetration of Islam to the interior parts of eastern and southern Ethiopia. Along the trade routes from Zeila, market centers were emerged .Gradually, the centers became centers of Muslim sultanates .The oldest Sultanate in Ethiopia was the Sultanate of Shewa. However, unlike northern Africa and other regions, in Ethiopia the processes of Islamization was not followed by the arabization. This was because Arabs did not open war of conquest against Ethiopia. and the Ethiopian converts remained with their national and ethnic identity. Moreover , in Ethiopia there was no large scale Arab migration.

UNIT 6

THE PRE-AKSUMITE STATES OF ETHIOPIA

6.1 ETHIOPIA AND THE CIVILIZED WORLD

6.1.1 ETHIOPIA AND EGYPT

Ethiopia had not been in a state of complete isolation from the rest of the world. There are evidences suggesting relation with Egypt, South Arabia, Israel, and Greco-Roman world.

Recent archaeological studies suggest that speakers of Proto-Afro Asiatic language occupied the area of North East Africa as a whole including Egypt. There are also evidences of close contact between peoples of ancient Egypt with ancient Ethiopia in terms of commercial matters particularly since the fourth million B.C. Studies on obsidian trade indicate the expansion of Egyptians toward the Southern African hinterland as far as the Horn of Africa in earlier times. The emerging elites of Egypt who aspired for prestige goods made the exchanges for such items with the Horn of Africa so intense in later times.

Egyptian monuments and hieroglyphics of the tombs of some pharaohs provided information on the countries, peoples, fauna and flora of the region lying to the South of Egypt. According to these sources, the oldest and the most frequently used as partner state to ancient Egyptians was “punt”.

According to some views, the state of punt extended from the area near Swakin or Massawa to the area even beyond the strait of Babel- Man dab and the cape of Gardafi in the Somalian coast. Nevertheless, based on considerations of the technical standard of the vessels of those days and the skill of the men who sailed them, the Egyptian vessels were not sufficiently well developed to resist and endure the moon soon wind. More over, ancient Egyptians had no knowledge of the direction of the wind. On the other hand, the west coast of the Red sea between the Swakin and Babel-Man dab was the safest side.

Based on those circumstantial evidences, the state of punt is assumed more probably being located in the region stretching from Eastern Sudan to the Red Sea region of Northern Ethiopia.

The peoples of the punt land were assumed to have belonged to the race of Hamitic stock that migrated to Africa and settled at a certain time around the coastal areas of the Red Sea. These peoples in any case were exporting different mineral, animal and plant products to ancient Egypt. Gold, Gold dust, silver, eye cosmetic, Apes, Asses, Bulls, Ostrich feathers, calves, Rhinoceros Horn, Ebony, Resin, Myrrh, Cinnamon, Wood, Balsam etc were among the items exported to Egypt from the land of Punt. Some of these products were indispensably important for the Egyptians. For example, Frankincense and Myrrh used for ritual purposes and were extremely demanded products. In general, the Egyptians needed such and other products of the punt for ritual use, cosmetics, perfumes, drugs, aromatics and for the manufacture of garments, instruments, etc ,purposes

As mentioned above, the relation between the two regions could be as old as the Egyptian history itself. There are clear evidences suggesting Egyptian expedition sent to this area since the time of the V dynasty (C. 2743-2731 B.C). The expedition is said to have succeeded in its mission of bringing great quantities of myrrh, ebony and electron. The relation, however, was not characterized by regular contact. Whenever there occurred difficulties in Egypt, the connection of any sort would have been off. The expedition, the Egyptians made, particularly in later times however mentioned significantly some of the names of tribes and places, which are equivalent to those in Ethiopia. The best-documented Egyptian expedition of the time was the expedition sent to the land of punt by Queen Hatshepsut of the XVIII dynasty. This expedition described the king of punt as Perehu.

In general, due to the absence of systematic archaeological excavations in Ethiopia to estimate the entire extent of Egyptian influence in the region the relation ship was strictly associated to commerce. There fore, no comprehensive views on the aspects of Egyptian influence on the ancient Ethiopians found except trade.

In spite of these limitations, it is assumed that the Egyptian had left their influence in some technologies like boat, beads and bracelets which still used and worn in the Ethiopian highlands. The beds & bracelets are similar to those seen on the engravings of Egyptian monuments.

Eye cosmetics of the Egyptian and Ethiopian women still bear the same name “Kohl”. The use of incense in ritual practices, and the name the word Etan and sistra (musical instrument) have the same name in Egypt & Ethiopia. The stele at Aksum dedicated to the god Horns had inscriptions related to the hieroglyphics of the Egyptian dynasties

6.1.2. ETHIOPIA AND THE ARABIAN WORLD

In the past, scholars had usually considered the contact between the Horn of Africa and the Near East as being started only in the first millennium B.C. Sources indicated that the merchant peoples of the Arabian region had settled in the Ethiopian highland around 1000 B.C. Nevertheless, they had been in a constant communication with the people of Ethiopian region. The Habashat and the Agazian (Gaze) were tribes who migrated to Ethiopia. The Arabian inscriptions and the Adulis inscription indicated such process.

There are also place names that survived in Ethiopian still to day though with some corrupt form. Examples are:

Sahart in Tigray – Sahartan in Arabia

Hauzen in ” - Hausan in Arabia

Madara in ” - Madran in Arabia

Ahsea (near yeha) – Ahsiyan in Arabia

Coloe near senate – Cullai in Arabia

Historians also explain that, in terms of Architecture, irrigation, agriculture, political organization religion and language, the Sabaeen may have their own influence on the local Ethiopia civilization.

The art of building house from stone in rectangular shape might be the influence of the Arabians. Such buildings are found at yeha. The temple of yeha (built 7th – 5th B.C) showed a striking similarity with the temple in South Arabia. Probably the most

important of such Arabian influence is reflected in political organization. The Mukarrib system that experienced absolute power had hold three power. He acted as high priest, absolute judge and commander in chief in the battlefield. This type of political organization had existed in Ethiopia.

6.1.3. ETHIOPIA AND THE MEDITERRANEAN WORLD

Unlike the Egyptian Nile Valley and the Red Sea Arabian world, Ethiopian relation with the Mediterranean region is relatively recent. The existing evidence suggests only to the Greek and Roman times. This contact compared to what we have seen above is very recent. Some of the evidences particularly that states relation with Israel are based on religious and legendary backgrounds.

Ethiopia had direct relations with the Hellenistic world where the Greek language and Greek civilization in general expanded. Even the name Ethiopia is of Greek origin. According to the Greeks Ethiopia means the country of men with burnt faces. It also designates the region of East Africa that lays South of Egypt. At different times, different travelers had come to this region of Africa. Some of them like Ptolemy wrote a book, *Aethiopia*, on the Ethiopians. He considered the country as sources of Elephant.

In general, the Greeks knew the region and merchants from the Graeco-Roman world came to the region frequently. Even they interested to establish friendly relations with the rest of North East Africa. With the aim of facilitating transportation of elephants and other commodities of North East Africa, there were garrisons established along-the cost of the Red Sea by the Greeks.

Aksumite coins had engravings Greek legend and this is an important source of evidence. In addition, Greek gods were known to the Ethiopians. Posiedon, Zeus, Ares, and other gods were worshiped in Ethiopia. Greek language, however, marked an important new development in Ethiopian history in the sense that Greek influence was the second element after south Arabian on the development of the Aksumite civilization.

Romans, though intended to send an army to subdue Ethiopians in 29 B.C, their relation with the ancient Ethiopians remained only commercial. They, in general, had economic and political aspiration of contact with Ethiopia.

6.2 THE PRE-AKSUMITE STATES

6.2.1 THE STATE OF PUNT

As we have mentioned earlier, the development of Agriculture and trade led to the emergence of classes and states. According to the existing evidence, the earliest name that belongs to the pre-Aksumite period is the state of punt. Ancient Egyptian sources indicate that there was commercial relationship between Egypt and the land of Punt.

Focus

The development of Agriculture and trade led to the emergence of classes and states. According to the existing evidence, the earliest name that belongs to the pre-Aksumite period is the state of Punt.

There is no clearly known explanation among scholars on the exact location of the state of punt mainly due to the lack of evidences. Some historians believe that punt was located in what is now northern or northeastern Somalia. Others argue that it was located in Northern Ethiopia. In spite of these controversies, punt was the earliest pre-Aksumite state in the Horn of Africa.

6.2.2 YEHA

Unlike the land of punt, we have better evidence about Yeha. It is situated east of Aksum. According to existing evidence, Yeha was emerged in about 1000 B.C. Historians strongly associate with the South Arabian immigrants of the early first millennium B.C. Some archaeologists also argue that in the first millennium B.C. Northern Ethiopia including Eritrea came under the commercial control, at least influence, of the kingdom of Saba of Northern Yemen. The consequence of these inter regional activity is the rise of some ancient states in Northern Ethiopia. A society urban in its socio- cultural aspect arose in the region. These sites include, among others, Yeha. Geographically, Yeha is found in western Tigray.

6.2.3 HAWLTI-MELAZO

The history of ancient people is hidden in the remote ages. Nevertheless, the absence of evidences creates difficulty to explain and trace the origin of those events. Ethiopian ancient history has similar experience. Nevertheless, there are few sites yielding evidences on the existence of ancient state or the ancient history of the region. Hawlti and Melazo are among the few sites that provide us with pre-Aksumite remains. The two sites are found in Tigray around the valley of May Agazen. The rich remains of these two sites had attracted the attention of archaeologists. Since 1955, several archaeological excavations have been conducted at Hawlti-Melazo. Archaeologists have discovered female status, sculptures of a bull and an ibex, various brownz objects, complex structures of temples and other buildings with staircases.

6.2.4 METARA, KESKESE AND COLOE

These are other sites of historic importance belonging to the pre-Aksumite period. Matara is located midway between the town of Aksum and the port of Massawa. Afray conducted an intensive archaeological excavation at Metara between 1959 and 1965. He discovered a stele, rock-cut tombs, a building complex, artifacts and various objects made gold, brownze and stone.

Keskesse is found in what is now central Eritrea. Some archaeological findings show that it had been an important settlement in the pre-Aksumite times. The name Coloe does not exist today but it is mentioned in some ancient sources.

6.2.5 ADULIS

As we mentioned above, Adulis was an important commercial center (port) before and during the Aksumite period. It was located on the coast of the Red Sea just near the present location of Massawa. Some archaeological remains that belong to the pre-Aksumite period have been discovered at Adulis. It is believed that Adulis had been a prominent port during both the pre-Aksumite as well as the Aksumite times.

Focus

Some archaeological remains that belong to the pre-Aksumite period have been discovered at Adulis. It is believed that Adulis had been a prominent port during both the pre-Aksumite as well as the Aksumite times.

6.2.6 DMT OR DAMAT

Our knowledge about Dmt or Damat is based on inscriptions. It is not exactly known whether Dmt was the name of the king or kingdom. However, according to Fattovich who carried out extensive archeological finding in the region, Damat was a kingdom in Northern Ethiopia that arose as the result of Ethio-Soudi Arabian trade. It flourished from about 700 to 400 B.C. After its creation about 700 to 400 B.C on the plateau, Damat soon included into its territory most of the Tigrean plateau from central Eritrea to Western Tigray. It is also assumed that this pre-Aksumite state was characterized actually by strong south Arabian influence with possible contact with the Nubian kingdom of Kush, the Achaemenian Empire, and possibly the Greek world. They for instance worshipped the principal god of south Arabia Almuqah.

The state of Damat (Dmt) apparently disappeared, in the late first millennium B.C. There is no royal inscription found after the fourth century B.C. mentioning the state of Damat. The archaeological study indicated the collapse of the urban society at least in western Tigray during this time.

As we have seen in the previous section, the Cushitic was spreading from North to south much earlier than the emergence of the above-mentioned pre-Aksumite states. Some scholars like Christopher Ehret argued that several older themes continuous to work themselves out in the history of the regions of the Horn- East and South of Aksumites sphere of influences.

SUMMARY

States were formed because of the growth of surplus production (growth of agriculture) and the class differentiation that it gave rise to. This process was facilitated with the growth of trade, particularly the external trade because of higher revenue it yielded and the wider contact it fostered. Accordingly, a number of states were emerged in Ethiopia and the Horn but because of lack of information we have no detail information on each of them. The oldest state for which we have some historical evidence is that of the state of Punt. Coming nearer time, we have the state of Damat. Damat is the immediate predecessor of Aksum, with its political center a little to the south of Aksum. The process of state and class formation was accompanied by the growth of urbanization. Thus, we

have a number of urban centers in today northern Ethiopia such as Yeha, the oldest urban settlement.

UNIT 7

THE AKSUMITE STATE

7.1 THE ORIGIN OF THE AKSUMITE STATE

As we have seen, Northern Horn of Africa is very rich in ancient remains. The cultural history of the region is marked by the spread of food producing communities particularly between the fourth and second millennia B.C. This was also followed by the rise of chiefdoms in the low lands and perhaps on the plateau in the third to second millennia B.C. The formation of states on the plateau, however, showed remarkable advances on the first millennium B.C. The population practice agriculture and trade in the region. These factors are important for the early emergence of state and these same factors are again contributory to the formation of the Aksumite state. It is clear, however, that Aksum emerged by exploiting the local but preceding socio-cultural and political background of the region. Some writers, for example, argue that in the late pre-Aksumite phase from about 300 B.C. On wards, the kingdom of Damat collapsed. Nevertheless, petty kingdoms probably survived on the plateau. At the end of the B.C. and early A.D era, the kingdom of Aksum arose on the Tigrean plateau. There is, however, clear gaps particularly on issues like when and how did it arise. Some sources totally associate the rise of Aksum to the middle of 2nd century B.C. While others associate it beginning to 100/200 A.D. Nevertheless, there are strong suggestions that around the close of the first millennium B.C. and the beginning of the first millennium AD, Aksumite kingdom arose on the Tigrean plateau. The kingdom at its initial stage included most of Eritrea and Tigray.

The Aksumite culture emerged from local traditions, including partly the pre-Aksumite one. A typical features of this culture was the large funerary stelae, up to 33m high, derived from stelae making “Gash Group” burial tradition in western low lands. This suggests a cultural link with the late prehistoric chiefdoms of the low lands. But this local route may be enhanced more and more gradually with external input or influence.

There are evidences suggesting the increased contact of Aksum with the outside world. It had close links with Egypt, Greco-Roman, Arabian, China and India, Persia etc of the states of the period. The presence of coins of other states as well as inscriptions attest such contact as the result of which Aksum became prosperous, powerful and territorially expanded.

Regarding the meaning of the word Aksum there is no clear vision on the meaning and origin of the word Aksum. There are different views in this regard. Some argue that the word Aksum came from Semitic term to mean a green and dense garden full of grass. This was because the area was dense of forest. Others view it as partially Agaw in origin “Ak” or “AKU” means water, where as the suffix “sum” is Semitic and means chief. According to this assumption, it means “chief’s water”. In Northern Ethiopia (North East of Aksum), there is a well, which is still called Maishum. It is the same as Ak +sum. But Maishum is a full Semitic term. Traditional views on the other hand associate it with the name of a legendary emperor, Aksumawi. Some Ethiopian scholars still attempted to show that the word was derived from a Geez verb- ማርሰ meaning to dedicate. According to some Geez texts, Aksum means the name of a place so to say the site of diamond.

In spite of the controversies on the meaning and origin of the name Aksum, there are epigraphic monuments and literature in different languages: Greek, Sabaeen, Geez and Latin that mentions the name Aksum and Aksumite at least from the 1st century of the Christian era. Recently inscriptions discovered in South Arabia also refer both Aksum and Aksumite.

Existing evidences particularly inscriptions discovered from Northern Ethiopia described both names. Another important issue is the question whether Aksum was an empire or a kingdom. Some sources like the inscriptions of Sembathes the Great, the oldest inscription ever discovered bears the term “king of kings”. This is also repeated by Ezana in the 4th century A.D. suggesting that Aksum was an empire. From geographic standpoint, the Aksumite rule extended beyond the Red Sea and it consisted of different ethnic and cultural groups. This also implies the term empire. The Greek inscription

found written probably in the first A.D. found on the hill of Abba Pentelewon mentioned that the territory of Aksum extended as far as the other side of the Red Sea. The inscription also claims that Greek language had penetrated to the inland parts of the empire. In general, Aksum was an empire with wide geographic extent. In the East, the territory stretched from the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden and to the West as far as the present Ethio-Sudanese border. Aksumite kings had even territory on the other side of the Red Sea. They controlled South Arabia (what is now Yemen) between the 3rd and 6th centuries A.D. The Aksumite kingdom therefore became a large empire and was more or less as powerful as the great powers of the time: Eastern Roman (Byzantine) and Persian Empires. But as attempts are made to narrate, Aksum did not emerge into such a strong power within a short period.

According to some scholars, the Aksumite Era can be divided into three broad periods (stages) of history.

- **The Early Aksumite phase:** - This phase describes Aksum from its formation to the introduction of Christianity. It at this time made initial expansions of territories. The eastern plateau (central Eritrea and Eastern Tigray) and the Western plateau (Western Tigray) were distinct regions of the Aksumite cultural area. There was the tradition of using carved Stelae to mark royal and elite cemeteries.
- **The Middle Aksumite phase (from about 400 A.D. to 700 AD):**- This phase corresponds to the period of major expansion of the kingdom. The Western and Eastern plateau shared the same material culture. Coinage was widely used. Churches were widely scattered over the territory of the kingdom.
- **The Late Aksumite phase (C. 700-900 A.D).** This phase correspond to the decline of the kingdom. Coinage was probably no more in use. Some important towns, such as Matara and Adulis were apparently abandoned. Aksum was quite reducing in size.

7.2 TRADE DURING THE AKSUMITE EMPIRE

As we mentioned above, the Aksumite contact with different regions and states have long history. There was reestablishment of the Erythrean sea route from Rome to

India and East Africa during the Aksumite period. And Aksum had witnessed the development of commercial competition in the region. As stated above, the commercial competition and growth set in motion in the region in the final three centuries of the first millennium B.C contributed to the consolidation of political power in Northern Ethiopia including Aksum.

The emergence of Aksum as a powerful Empire in turn represented a new centralized flow of international trade and a damping down of the competitive forces at work in the Red Sea regions in commercial affairs. The south Arabian inscriptions indicate many references to the heavy traffic between Ethiopia and South Arabia.

A key tactic in Aksumite commercial policy from the first to the seventh century A.D. was the maintenance of a single major coastal entrepot, Adulis. With the decline of contacts between Greco-Roman in the Eastern sphere, Adulis emerged as a termination point of Greco-Roman trade to the South and East Asian territories. Indian trade with the western world was left freely to the Ethiopians. The Ethiopians were delivering Indian products to the Romans at Adulis. Aksum was, therefore, the state that controlled the whole of Indian trade to the West in the third century A.D. African previous export items such as ivory, slave and metal fell in to the hands of the Ethiopians.

Restricting the activities of foreign merchants to Adulis allowed efficient collection of trade duties that supported the state and its military power. The local and international trade had therefore played such a central place in the Aksumite economy. Moreover, a network of trade routes connected Aksum with important markets within the empire and the main port on the Red sea coast. The major road in the country led from Adulis to the city of Aksum. There were also secondary routes passing through out the high land towns. Aksumite merchants and hunters followed still other paths of trade deep in to the interior even beyond the Tekeze where obtaining ivory was a principal objective. By the sixth Century A.D. the route to the south west may have brought another product, gold, to the North from as far away as the Abay river at the Eastern edge of the middle Nile Basin.

The collection of duties on the trade provided kings with the revenues to support military campaigns and to afford the growing power of the empire.

According to the Periplus of the Erythrean Sea, Adulis was described as a port established by law. It also states the Greek participation in the trade. Periplus of the Erythrean Sea was a handbook written by a certain Greek merchant probably around the mid 1st A.D. A port established by law suggesting the presence of many foreigners dealing in exports. This implies some sort of agreement with the local government, a trading place where law applies, or a trading place where traders are protected by law.

Focus

According to the Periplus of the Erythrean Sea, Adulis was described as a port established by law. It also states the Greek participation in the trade. Periplus of the Erythrean Sea was a handbook written by a certain Greek merchant probably around the mid 1st A.D. A port established by law suggesting the presence of many foreigners dealing in exports. This implies some sort of agreement with the local government, a trading place where law applies, or a trading place where traders are protected by law.

In general, Ethiopia was carrying on trade with different peoples and most of them were established by law. The export articles of Ethiopia were sent first to Egypt and from there they passed to Greece and father to the Western world.

According to contemporary sources, ivory, incense, spices, gold, rhinoceros horn, hippopotamus hide, tortoise shell, were exported to the outside world through Adulis. As you can see, most of the export items were animal products. On the other hand, textiles, glass, jewelry, metal tools, olive oil, wine and various utensils were the main items that Aksum had been importing. The involvement of Aksum into such comprehensive and dominant international trade enabled it to mint coins of its own as well as encouraged the building of ships. You may find it interesting to note that the Aksumite kings had merchant ships sailing across the Red sea and the Indian Ocean. It is equally interesting to note that between the third and seventh centuries A.D., Askumite rulers minted gold, silver and bronze coins. These coins bear Greek and Geez letters symbols as well as images of the Aksumite kings surrounded with stalks of wheat or barely. In addition to the inscriptions, the discovery of Aksumite coins in South Arabia, Israel, Egypt and Sudan clearly demonstrates that the Aksumite currency had international acceptance.

7.3 SOCIETY AND CULTURE IN AKSUM

Aksum as the capital represented a particular center of monumental building, including among its many large buildings, a multistory royal palace. The towns became centers as well as artistic endeavors, supported probably most often by royal patronage in Aksum, but perhaps also by regional authorities and rich merchants in provincial powers. The most imposing works of art were the enormous steles or pillars of Aksum, the largest of which stood over 30 meters.

A sharp social dichotomy between town and country probably characterized the kingdom of Aksum. In city and town, a multi layered social formation had evolved early, probably already incipient in the city-state of Yeha. The language of the towns and of commerce was Geez, a language derived from that of immigrant south Arabians.

At the top was the court or in provincial towns, the government authorities. A merchant class, a class of artisans and skilled workers, and a majority stratum of servants, including probably some slaves, constituted the remainder of the urban population. Outside the towns, the older ethnic and clan connections still guided day-to-day affairs. Agaw continued to be the language of the countryside all through the central parts of the kingdom.

When we examine the political influence of the Aksumites, we found that foreign politics of the kings of Aksum recurrently expressed two central aims. One is control of the African outlets of the Red sea. The second point is bringing the South Arabian land routes of the trade into the Akumite sphere of influence. In practice, these policy goals were attained by conquest of the Red sea hills and by episodes of Akumite invasion and rule over parts of South Arabia. The successful establishment by the middle of the first century A.D of Adulis as single major port of Aksum on the Red Sea reflects the first stage of implementation of such policies. From documents dating to the fourth century A.D , it appears that Aksumite rulers succeeded in spreading their power and influence north along the Red sea and into parts of South Arabia during the second and third centuries A.D.

However, since early on, Aksum was exerting its influence on oversea territories. Historic evidence including inscription indicate the extension of Ethiopian dominion to the coastal strip on the Eastern shore of the Red sea, a location of strategic and commercial significances since the early history of Aksum. Among the earliest Aksumite king, Gadar is said to have intervened actively in South Arabian affairs. The Sabaeen inscription attests this. The army of the Aksumite king was active in controlling overseas territories. Nevertheless, the expansion to the east and possible occupation of territories were not without clash.

Not only Aksum intended to influence Arabia but also the Romans. It is mentioned that Aksum had maintained trade relation with Romans. The Romans had also showed keen interest in improving and guaranting its relation with North East Africa. The interests of both Aksum and Rome on the same region and resource might have led them to clashes and long-range wars. Nevertheless, we have clear evidence only for the presence of friendly relations in between. The summary of existing evidences demonstrates friendly relation between Rome and Aksumite kings of the 2nd century AD. The recent excavations at Matara revealed fourteen Roman gold coins of the 2nd and 3rd centuries A.D. All of them bear rings for attachment and consequently they may have been used as ornaments. Even the political relation of the two was generally taking place indirectly through the intermediary of another kingdom. In fact, it has been stated in some sources that the Aksumites might have occupied the Roman territories around the Red sea. They also prevented the Romans from claiming their tribute but there is no evidence of war in between.

There are sufficient evidences still indicating the paramount political influence Aksumite rulers had in oversea territories particularly south Arabia. There were also occasions where treaty of peace and friendship signed between the Ethiopians and the Sabaeans. But things were not all peaceful so that the advent of the Ethiopian army in south Arabia not only safeguarded the area rather they also inflicted heavy losses on the allied forces of Arabians. According to Wissmann, the first Ethiopian occupation in Arabia lasted over one and a half centuries, from 80 or 90 AD to 265 AD.

The rise of Aksumite power appears to have had severe consequence for Meroe. Aksum's gaining of control over the Red sea outlets would have restricted the access of Meroites to their accustomed markets. There are indirect indications that new strength of Aksum led to an increasing diversion of the products of the middle Nile Basin, such as exotic skins, ivory and gold directly in to Aksumite hands, by passing the Meroitic stretches of the Nile. Meroitic influence seems to have receded rapidly after the first AD. Aksum then after came to be considered by the Romans as the third great power in their known world, along with their own empire and the empire of the Parthian and, later, of the Sassanids in Persia.

In general, Aksumite civilization was flourishing from different angles. The empire extended its dominion along both sides of the Red sea coast. There was a central government headed by an Emperor with a title of king of kings. The emperor had a worldwide reputation. The Ethiopian realm did not remain culturally dependent on South Arabia and Greece. It developed its own unique culture so that Ethiopia became the only country in Africa to have its own written language. This development of a written language is eloquent proof of the degree of civilization attained by the Aksumites. Since Aksum had a military power with skilled art of strategy and logistics and perhaps possessions. Aksumites often made an aggressive policy and control and influence on the trade and activities of the neighboring states. The reign of Ezana and Caleb are ,in particular, among the most distinguished in Aksumite period.

During the time of king Ezana, Aksum reached the Zenith of its prosperity and power. His reign also marked the first detailed record of events of the period available to scholars. In other words, the sources of his period are abundant and his history is well document. There are inscriptions in three languages (Geez, Greek and Sabaeen called Triangular inscriptions of Ezana), Coins as well as written sources by difference foreign scholars. The triangular inscription of Ezana were written in the first half of the four the AD.

The Geez inscription of Ezana, for instance, added the peoples of Aguazat who rebelled against him and refused to pay tribute. According to the inscription, they were subdued after the expedition led by the king himself. The conquest of the Serene of 'Afan, in the Northern part of his kingdom' were dealt with force for they attacked and killed a merchant caravan on the occasion Ezana erected a throne in honour Gods of Aster, Bahir and Midir. The other characterizing feature of Ezana is his adoption of Christianity. Although the introduction of Christianity to Aksum might be earlier some time, Ezana was considered as the first among the Aksumite emperors to accept Christianity.

The reign of Ezana was noted with the development of Geez language. In spite of such development of Aksumite Empire, some source suggested that a capable king did not succeed Ezana. Moreover, the fifth century Ethiopian history is very badly documented. Except for some coins, we do not have any epigraphic sources. The period from the end of the reign of Ezana until the appearance of Caleb may be considered as the little Dark Age of Ethiopia.

There are no direct reasons to explain the decline of Aksum after Ezana. However, the period then after was characterized by so many rebels triumphed and the emperors were unable to rule the country in space and tranquility. Still, however, Adulis was the main port of the Roman for Eastern trade and Ethiopians were the only, intermediaries between the East the west. We hear nothing further about the Ethiopian occupation in south Arabia after the reign of Ezana. Due to the absence of a strong and powerful emperor of Aksum, it seems that this overseas territory was lost for a short period. In the late fifth century AD, Tazena undertook an expedition to impose his sovereignty in South Arabia and succeeded in doing so. His policy continued under his son Caleb, the emperor who reconsolidated Ethiopian rule over south Arabia.

It is, therefore, possible to point that the revival of the power and prosperity of Aksum after a dark period of about one hundred and fifty years (following Ezana) was attained in Ethiopian history at the beginning of the sixth century with the reign of Caleb. It is evidenced from coin and epigraphic sources. According to inscriptions, Ella Asbeha was

another name of the Emperor- Caleb. Caleb as a reflection to parts of his reign built church at Aksum, consecrated the cathedral and created a throne for God. During the reign of Caleb, Ethiopia reached new heights in many aspects of civilization culture, economy, commerce and administration. Even his empire appears to have been even larger than that of Ezana. Vasilieu described this period as “the last brilliant page in the history of Aksum”.

Focus

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Caleb was also known in world history for his expedition to Arabia. He controlled greater territory in South Arabia than ever before. The Arabian kingdom of Himyar and Saba as well as Nagran were under his authority. In the 6th c, there were Ethiopian garrisons in key positions like Zafar and Nagran. They had fortified the cities strongly so that they might not be occupied by the enemy force. For consolidating their occupation, the Ethiopians were also trying to convert the people to the Christian faith. This religious policy of the Aksumites had grievous consequences for the presence of the Ethiopians in that region. Since the political and religious policies of the Aksumites were in conflict with the sentiments of the indigenous inhabitants of Arabia, the Arabs had opposed Ethiopian sovereignty. The Arabians did their best to gain their independence by any possible means. One of these ways was through religious alignment.

Archeological sources discovered and the available Geez inscriptions indicate that the persecution in Arabia was mainly directed against the Ethiopians who inhabited various places in South Arabia in the first quarter of the sixth century. It also indicates that the Ethiopian emperor undertook a retaliatory expedition.

Under their ruler Dhu Nuwas the South Arabians beheaded about 300 Ethiopians at the town of Zafar. Christian churches were closed and set on fire and the Christians who were inside the church burned alive. Those who were not in the church were ordered to renounce the Christian faith and embrace Judaism on pain of death. After the persecution at Zafar, Dhu Nuwas went on another important Ethiopian center, Nagran in the North of

South Arabia. Like Zafar, here, there were many Christians from the Mediterranean world as well. The town was captured, the Christians were executed, and churches were burnt down.

In order to exploit the advantage of the effect of monsoon wind on navigation, Dhu Nuwas conducted most of his expedition against the Christians during winter season. The persecution however caused reverberations in all Christian countries and gave rise to works in prose and verse in different languages: Greek, Syriac, Arabic, Ethiopia, Latin and Armenian.

Caleb after being informed about the incident began to take actions. Foreign ships came for commercial purposes hired to transport his army to South Arabia. Altogether, Caleb collected a total of 230 ships from sources within the country and from overseas. He anchored them at a port called Gabazan, near Adulis. Caleb sent by land 15,000 soldiers to attack Saba from the South and he himself intended to cross the Red Sea by ship and attack from the west. However, his soldiers perished in the desert from lack of food and water as well as the extreme climatic conditions.

In 523 A.D Caleb send expedition with large army. He arrived safely at the coast near Mokha, which was the main port of South Arabia at the time. He took twelve ships with him and sailed further to the East hoping to be able to land some where in that direction. In the meantime, the Ethiopians began to suffer from a shortage of good. Eventually however, Caleb succeeded in combating the army of the Arabs. Then Caleb restored the churches, which were destroyed and he appointed ruler of the Ethiopian territory in South Arabia. Although he scored victory and returned to Aksum by leaving his army in South Arabia, the situation in South Arabia was not greatly changed. There was another attempt of attack. Dhu Nuwas, by preparing & equipping himself well, began to launch an assault on the Ethiopians with ferocity. Hence, Caleb was forced to prepare himself for another expedition and he came for the second time to South Arabia in 525 AD. This expedition was a decisive blow to the force of Dhu Nuwas. The Aksumites were, thus, remained active in the region in the sixth Century. Some time after his triumphant victory, Caleb is

said to have been voluntarily abdicated the throne and entered monastic life in the hermitage of Abba Pentelewon where he ended his days probably in 535 A.D.

His rule in south Arabia was left to Summyafa 'Aswa'. Nevertheless, in about 543, Abreha revolted and seized power without the knowledge of Aksumite emperor in the home country. The emperor of Aksum might have intended to carry out expedition to south Arabia against Abreha. Nevertheless, Abreha systematically submitted to emperor and started to rule the region by paying tribute to Aksum. Upon submission to the Emperor of Aksum, Abreha started programs to improve the administration in the region. He also carried out territorial expansion both eastwards and Northwards of his exception in south Arabia.

In order to gain economic and religious upper hand, Abreha even tried to open trade routes to the north, constructed dams and churches in his empire. With the construction and completion of church, Abreha had also calculated that he would divert pilgrimages from Mecca to Sana (his capital). However, he faced with oppositions from Arabia during which he was forced to carry out expedition to Mecca in 570 AD. to destroy the Kaba. Abreha's march however brought destruction and the cavalry brought back all the booty to the camps of Abreha.

Upon the death of Abreha, Yaksum succeeded him on the throne in South Arabia who continued the later policy of his father (Abreha) and paid tribute to the Emperor. Yaksum and his successor Masruk were less effective in ruling south Arabia. Masruk who eventually went into war with the south Arabians was defeated by the Arabs under the Persian support. This all marked that the south Arabians became a territory of Persian and massacre on the Ethiopians pursued. According to some sources, Ethiopian rule over the region could have ended in 575 AD. The loss of the overseas territory dealt a hard blow to the prestige of Aksum. Aksum ceased to be considered as the third big power of that time, a position she had enjoyed since the third century of our era. In the meantime, the Byzantine Empire had also broken off all ties with the Aksumite Empire.

7.4 AKSUM IN THE SEVENTH CENTURY

After the occupation of south Arabia by Persia, Aksumite Empire ceased to play a leading role particularly in politics. Yet, there was still the influence of the Ethiopians who settled in North Arabia. They penetrated into every sphere of society be domestic or artistic. However, their major contribution was the economic and military aspect of life. Ethiopian ships, which were large and fast, engaged in carrying African products such as ivory, slaves and gold to Arabia and in bringing back all the commodities of the Near East. Commerce flourished, particularly between Aksum and the Quraysh of Mecca. The Venetians of Arabs had no proper port, instead, the Aksumite ships anchored in the Bay of Soaiba facing the desert. The Quraysh had extensive commercial activity and concluded treaty of commerce with Aksum as well as Byzantine and Persia empires. Within the republic of Mecca itself, Ethiopians also played an important role in organizing the army a responsibility entrusted to them by the Meccans. Even the main body of the army of the republic of Mecca was made in the hands of Ahabis- the Ethiopians.

The increase of commerce and wealth necessitated the recruitment of more soldiers from among the Bedouins and slaves, but this did not change the structure and character of the existing military organization and the name Ahabis was retained.

Not only Aksumite influence existed and reflected in south Arabia at this time but it also prevailed in the neighbouring country of Nubia. The politico-religious activities of Aksum were thus directed North wards to Nubia. For example, Christianity was introduced to them from Aksum. The evidence of Aksumite penetration in the region could be traced back to the fourth C, there were also evidences of such influence particularly in religious teaching in Nubia in 580 A.D.

In the early seventh century, Aksum was supposed to have maintained relations with Byzantine Empire. There was a sort of concerted action between the Byzantine and Ethiopian emperors against Persians towards the end of the sixth and early seventh centuries.

7.5 DECLINE AND COLLAPSE OF AKSUM

At the beginning of the eighth century, Ethiopia found herself involved in both offensive and defensive wars. Relations with Umayyad caliphate of Yemen were for example unfriendly. There were hostilities being initiated from both sides. In 702 AD., Ethiopian forces invaded Jeddah and inflicted serious damage before marching on to Mecca. However, the Ethiopians were repulsed and in the same year, the Umayyad caliph attacked Ethiopian territory and occupied Dahlak. In spite of this occupation, the Ethiopians continued their activities in the Red Sea and in 768 A.D., the Ethiopians attempted another attack on Jeddah.

The whole matter of attack and counter attack, therefore, had economic rather than political implications i.e. securing market for their goods. There was commercial relation between Ethiopia and the Muslim world: the main route being through the Sudan and the Red sea. Gradually however difficulties in such smooth flow of trade occurred with the expansion of Islam to the region. Moreover, due to the internal problem in Egypt, the normal commercial relations between Ethiopia, Nubia and Egypt were interrupted. Some sources indicate on the other hand that there was renewed commercial activities and flourishing of trade between Ethiopia and the Arab world. Through the port of Dahlak (Massawa) and Badi passed goods bound for the Ethiopian interior and for Hijaz and Yemen. In fact, there was southward expansion of the Beja but they could not capture Dahlak. Hence, trade continued and Ethiopian items were even transported from Yemen to Baghdad.

From the beginning, the close commercial contact Ethiopia maintained with others had certain political and cultural influence. In Ethiopia, the impact of trade was largely reflected in cultural implications. Thus using Dahlak as a gateway, Islam possibly penetrated to the coastal regions and gradually to the interior of Ethiopia. Nevertheless, Ethiopia felt the pressure not only from the East, but also from the Beja tribes in the North. Especially, after 813 AD, the Beja concentrated their interest on Ethiopia. Since they were nomads, they began infiltrating Aksumite territory. The Beja were well organized in military so that the Ethiopians were not in a position to offend them. Time had changed. The struggle for survival had begun. The decline of Ethiopia that had

already started led to the most destructive consequence in the early tenth century. And the period from the end of the 9th to 12th C is generally considered as the “dark age” in the sense that there is a complete lack of internal source materials.

In general, Aksum that had once attained such fame and glory collapsed. The main reasons for their decline and fall are attributed to a number of factors. The rise of Islam and subsequent blockage of trading ports like Adulis as well as interruption on trade routes, lack of spiritual guidance of Aksumite rulers, economic deterioration, internal trouble like the Beja invasion and power struggle as well as environmental degradation are considered as some of the factors for the collapse of Aksum.

Focus

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The rise of Islam for instance had brought cultural as well economic repercussion of its own on Aksum. Ethiopia failed to have control of the whole of the Red sea, which was so vital for her external commercial activities. It presented a limit on the naval activities of Aksum and even some of its ships were definitely destroyed. Although the trade did not totally cease at the early phase of Islamic introduction, it had greatly influenced Aksum’s future destiny.

SUMMARY

Ethiopia had a number of ancient states. They are divided into pre-Aksumite and Akumite states. Most of these states are found in Northern part of Ethiopia. There were also states and parallel development in other parts. Nevertheless, there are only limited researches carried out on these regions as compared to the North.

Yeha, Hawilti Melazo, Metara, Kassasse, Daamt were few along the pre Aksumite states. There is evidence on the presence of Sabaeen influence on these states. But in these as well as earlier states like punt there is a local element (root) of civilization.

That is, the Ethiopian civilization is an internal or local or African civilization with an external influence.

By the middle of the second century B.C. and in the first century A.D., Aksum emerged as a state in Northern Ethiopia. It is assumed that Aksum emerged at the expense of the other small chiefdoms occurred in the region. Thus, Aksum is not the oldest state because there are a number of pre-Aksumite states. But it is the most developed state.

After its foundation, Aksum became gradually as a powerful nation of the world having political and even cultural influence on the surrounding states like Meroe and South Arabia. It also had trade relations with the Mediterranean, Red Sea and Indian Ocean world. Coins, inscriptions and ruins of buildings are some of our main sources to reconstruct the history of the region.

Aksum lost its power and glory following the gradual decline it had been experiencing since the rise of Islam in the Arabian world. The birth of Islam and its expansion was the main factor for the decline and fall of Aksum.

UNIT 8

THE ZAGWE DYNASTY

8. 1 EMERGENCE AND CONSOLIDATION OF THE ZAGWE DYNASTY

In the previous chapter, we have seen the decline and down fall of the Axumite Empire. The transfer of political power from the Axumite rulers to the Zagwe Dynasty was not, however, immediate. Rather it was a gradual process. Unfortunately, little is known about the period between the middle of the eighth and twelfth century due to lack of evidence. It was about the middle of the twelfth century, the Ethiopian state reappeared with its centre in what is today Lalibela, in the Agew interior of Wag and Lasta under a new Christian ruling house.

There are three possible assumptions regarding the origin of the word “Zagwe”. Some writers claim that it is an abbreviation of Zewge Michael, the christian name of Mera Tekle- Hymanot, the founder of the dynasty. Others believe that it derives from Agew, the place where the tribe originate. The Agew are one of the most ancient peoples of northern Ethiopia. They had long been included within the Axumite Empire. When the power of Axum declined in its northern provinces, it was among the Agew that the state shelter. The third assumption is that the word derives from the Ge’ez verb “>Ñ<¾¾¾” meaning “to pursue or to persecute.” Yet, it is the second explanation that seems the most probable since the previous Dynasty also took its name from a locality, and more specifically, a capital city – Aksum. But, the Zagwe did not establish a capital city which could symbolize the whole empire. Instead, they took the name of the region where the Agew people originated i.e., the north-centered part of Ethiopia.

The Agew of the region had long been converted to Christianity and they continued the ancient Aksumite political traditions almost intact. Despite change of location, there was continuity of civilization from Aksum to Zagwe. It is true that in other states or empires change in the location of the center of power has an effect on a civilization but in the case of Ethiopia, the effect was minimal only the external features of the civilization were

affected, not its essence. For example, there was continuity in pottery making, religion, writing, etc. It is rare in world history to find a civilization with roots so far back in time. Ethiopian civilization experienced only transitory change. Its physical center altered from Axum to Lalibela (Bugna) but not its characteristic features and substance. Therefore, we can say that the Aksumite civilization was the model and prototype, the fundamental base from which the Zagwe (even the civilization which exists today) is only a further extension. The state structure of the Zagwe dynasty was also very similar to that of Aksum. Christianity was an official religion of the dynasty.

Focus

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The Zagwe period had long been converted to Christianity and they continued the ancient Aksumite political traditions almost intact. Their territory included most of the highland provinces of the Aksumite kingdom in the north. In the south their power extended at least as far south as northern Shewa. There are strong traditions suggesting that they had established a firm presence in the region of Lake Tana and the northern part of what is today Gojjam. They also encouraged trade from the coasts of the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden through the Dahlak Islands and the port of Zeila, respectively.

The Zagwe rulers pursued an active policy of re-establishing more regular contacts with Egypt and the Holy places in Palestine. Like the Aksumite kings, they continued to bring patriarchs from the church of Alexandria in Egypt. The expansion of Christianity during the Zagwe period encouraged the revival and development of Ge'ez literature with the introduction of several documents a number of religious manuscripts were produced.

Because of the shortage of information, there is a problem about the exact date of the beginning of the Zagwe dynasty and the number of monarchs who ruled the country during this period. In attempting to date the beginning of the Zagwe rule, two important sources are:

- The description of Ibn Hawkal

- The letter of George of Nubia to patriarch philotheus

According these sources, the Dynasty started about in 1150 and continued until 1270.

With regard to the name of the rulers, we have three different kinds of lists collected by an Italian scholar E.Cerulli who wrote a book entitled “Storia d ‘Etiopia’. He listed the Zagwe rulers as follows.

Group- 1	Group- 2	Group- 3
1. Mera	1. Mera Tekle Hiamanot	1. Mera Tekle Haimanot
2. Yimreha	2. Tetewudem	2. Sibuhay, Dill Ne’ad II
3. Lalibela	3. Jan Seyoum	3. Meyrasy
4. Ne’akuto Le’ab	4. Girma Seyoum	4. Harbey, Hareyene Egzi
5. Harbe	5. Yimrehane Kristos	5. Menzisine Yitbarek
	6. Harbe	6. Yi’ Kebke Egzi
	7. Lalibela	7. Zena petros
	8. Ne’ akuto Le’ab	8. Bahr Saf
	9. Yitbarck	9. Tetwudem, Ser Assegid
	10. Meyraray	10. Akotet, Jan Seyoum
	11. Harbai	11. Be’mnet, Girma Seyoum
		12. Yimerchano Kristos
		13. Gebre Maryam
		14. Lalibela
		15. Ne’akuto Le’ab
		16. Yitbarck

The names in the first group are fewer in number and are abbreviated. The reverse is true for other two lists. If the duration of the Dynasty is about 300 years, the third list would seem the most accurate. For the most part of the period, we don’t have any recorded history of these emperors. The legendary sources are rare and inadequate. This lack of written materials is the view of churchmen that the Zagwe dynasty was illegitimate as the rulers took power from the Axumite or Solomonite king by force. The chroniclers were churchmen and thus their record of the period is usually summed up in one

sentence. “The kingdom was given to the people who didn’t belong to the Tribe of Israel”. That is, the Zagwe rulers were illegal rulers. In order to disprove this legend, there are two legends, the one based on Bible and the other on the life of queen of Sheba. The former emphasizes that the dynasty was descended from Moses as in numbers 12:1 reference is made that the king married an Ethiopian woman. The second legend is based on queen Sheba and king Solomon of Israel. It is said in the Bible that queen Sheba of Aksum went to Jerusalem to visit King Solomon accompanied by many maids. The king met with both on the same night. On their return to Ethiopia, both the queen and the servant gave birth on the same day. The queen’s son was called Menelik while the child of the servant was called Zage. This motive of circulating the two legends was for the following reasons: First, it emphasized their origins in Israel and secondly their precedence over the Solomonic dynasty. Despite their efforts, however, the Zagwe dynasty unable to gain recognition as the legitimate ruling power. The church’s strong objections did find support among the people. Still, the action of the church didn’t prevent some of the Zagwe rulers from being regarded as saints. A typical example was king Lalibela.

8.2 THE ROCK-HEWN CHURCHES OF LALIBELA

The Zagwe Dynasty is best remembered for the construction of rock-hewn churches. The churches are also called monolithic because they were built out of a living-rock. Rock-hewn churches were not new. There are many rock-hewn churches that were built in earlier times in Tigray. But it was during the Zagwe period that this tradition attained its highest level of refinement. Thus, the Zagwe churches witnessed some of the finest architectural and artistic achievements of the Christian world. As a result, churches of Lalibela have been recognized by UNESCO as part of the World Cultural Heritage. The best examples of this Zagwe architecture are concentrated at the political center, Adafa (today, Lalibela). They are 11 in number.

Focus

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Based on their location, the churches can be grouped into three.

Group I	Group II	Group III
1. Bete Mehane Alem	7. Bete Gebriel-Rufael	11. Bete Giyorgis
2. Bete Maryam	8. Bete Merqoryos	
3. Bete Mesqel	9. Bete Abba Libanos	
4. Bete Denagil	10. Bete Amanuel	
5. Bete Mikael		
6. Bete Golgota		

Group-one are built very close together. There is a channel connecting them. Group two are located about some distance from group-one. There is a small stream that divided the two groups. Bete Giyorgis is isolated from other churches. It has cross-shaped roof. It is also the most refined, well- designed and well-finished one.

With regard to the nature and style of their construction, the churches of Lalibela can also be divided into three groups.

1. **Cave Churches.** These are similar to a natural cave. They have one entrance and some internal divisions and decorations. Bete mesqel is a cave church.
2. **Semi-hewn churches.** These churches are not totally separated from the surrounding rock. Bete Golgota, Bete Denagil, Bete Libanos, Bete Merqoryos are few monolithic churches.
3. **Hewn (Monolithic) churches.** They are churches which are completely separated (caved out) from living rock. They are hewn on all sides including the roof. Bete Medhane Alem (which is the largest), Bete Maryam and Bete Giyorgis are hewn churches.

These churches were most probably constructed by Ethiopians because there are many monolithic churches existed in many years before the Zagwe dynasty. Here, we may raise an important question why Lalibela, the most famous king of the dynasty, constructed so many churches of varied size and type in one place? According to his *Gedle* (life history) there are two possible answers:

1. **Many Christians went to Jerusalem.** It was believed that a Christian should visit the Holy land at least once in his life. Thus many Ethiopians traveled through the deserts of Sudan and Egypt to Jerusalem. Many of them lost their life before arriving to Jerusalem. King Lalibela knew this problem. So he wanted to build another Jerusalem in Ethiopia as substitute. To this end, Lalibela designed these churches to symbolize both the heavenly and the earthly. Heaven is represented by the second group of churches; whereas the first groups of churches are concerned with the earthly Jerusalem. Therefore, the construction of these churches represented an attempt by Lalibela to discourage pilgrims from journeying to Jerusalem.
2. **King Lalibela was much denoted Christian.** He was expanding Christianity in his kingdom. The building of churches was part of the expansion of Christianity during the Zagwe rule.

Technologically, it is important to emphasize that the eleven monolithic churches of Roha are a continuation and development of Aksumite art and architecture. A comparison of their structure with that of the Aksumite buildings indicates that generally the art and architectural styles were inherited from Aksum, although some change and modification had taken place.

8.3 SHORT DESCRIPTION OF SOME CHURCHES

The following brief description of each church is intended to provide a better understanding of the artistic value of these churches.

- a) **Bete Medhane Alem:-** is a rectangular church. It is the largest of all churches- Externally, it is supported by 32 square columns while inside there are only 28. There are three doors.
- b). **Bete Maram-** is also a rectangular church. This church is the most highly decorated one.
- c) **Bete Meskel-** It has no decoration. It is almost the extension of the courtyard.
- d) **Bete Golgotha and Bete Michael** are separated by a wall. There are carved images representing Yohannis, Giyorgis, Qirqos and Estefanos. In Bete Golgotha, the tomb of Lalibela is found
- e) **Bete Giyorgis-** is built in the shape of a Greek cross style. It is finer than the others. Architecturally, its style is finer than the others because it might be built after the

architects had gained some experience. Its flat roof is ornamented with crosses and sculptures in relief. The walls reflect the Aksumite style of recessed and projecting stone work. There is also evidence of foreign influence.

8.4 THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE ROCK-HEWN CHURCHES

- a) **Religion:** The churches were a source of inspiration and hope for Ethiopian Christians because they were considered comparable in significance to those in Jerusalem. It is stated in the *Gedle Lalibela* that for anyone who visits these churches it is as if he has seen the face of Jesus Christ. For this reason, many people from different parts of Ethiopia undertook pilgrimage to Roha and still do particularly on Christian day. There is also a widespread belief that a Christian having been there gains eternal life in the next world.
- b) **Architecture:** The churches of Lalibela, as they are called today, are unique in a number of ways. First, there are so many all built from the same rock mass. Secondly, the dimensions and style of each church differs which shows the range of ability of Ethiopians in architecture. Moreover, the building of such churches from one mass of solid rock with such exactitude and symmetry is truly a human miracle. Alvares wrote, " ... the like of which and so many, can not, as it appears to me, be found in the world. These churches are unique and rank as the eighth wonde of the world.
- c) **Art:-** The bas-relief figures, the interior decorations, the walls, the pillars, the variety of window shapes and the general appearance of the exterior are both a source of inspiration to artists and sources of admiration to visitors. They conquer even the most barbaric heart of Ahmed Gagn , a fanatical opponent of Christianity and Christian monuments, who came to these magnificent churches but withdrawal his army without damaging them. They are, in fact, one of the few monuments, which escaped destruction at his hand. They are a memorial to the level of civilization reached during the period of the Zagwe dynasty.

D) Economic Significance:- For Ethiopia, these churches were, and still are, of economic importance. Today, Roha is one of the most popular tourist attractions in the country.

8.5 THE DECLINE AND FALL OF THE ZAGWE DYNASTY

The Zagwe dynasty survived until 1270 AD. Sometimes before 1270, the dynasty seems to be weakened by the following factors.

A. Political succession: The Zagwe rulers were unable to arrange a smooth political succession. The death of a king was usually followed by a serious power struggle within the ruling family. As a result, the dynasty was weakened by internal political crisis. Following the death of Lalibela, for example, there was considerable confusion. There was a struggle for power between his legitimate son Yitbarek and his nephew Ne'akuto Le'ab. The economic crisis which had begun during the life time of Lalibela provoked rebellion. Finally, Yekuno Amlak, who was not a member of the Zagwe Dynasty, got the chance to involve in the power struggle. The loss of central control provided an opportunity to get supporters against the Zagwe rulers.

Focus

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B. The Church: The rulers of Zagwe were considered as usurpers priests like Tekle-Hymanot and Iyesus Mo'a in particular favored the Solomonic dynasty. The two priests were the architects of the restoration of the Solomonic line. In those days, the church assumed a more important and influential role in the society. Thus, they were able to bring the Amharas and Tigreans on the side of Yekuno Amlak who was relative of Tekle-Hymanot and in the service of the emperor, Yitbarek. To their objectives, Yekuno Amlak and other non-Zagwe elements started to use the legend about king Solomon and Queen of Shaba. They claimed that they descended from the Aksumite king, Menilek I, but the Zagwe rulers had illegally taken power from the legitimate "Solomonic kings of Aksum". Of course, these legendary claims were obviously not sufficient to ensure Yekuno Amlak's success. There are indications that he had to fight his way to the throne, defeating the last Zagwe king, Yitbarek with the

help of a series of military alliances with the chieftains of Amhara (Present day southern Wello) and northern Shewa.

- C) The Emergence of Zeila as import- export business center. But the Zagwe rulers did not share from the income trade of Zeila because it was under the control of Muslims. The economic decline brought military decline.

SUMMARY

- The Zagwe civilization was the continuity of the Aksumite civilization . There was continuity of culture and traditions from Aksum to Zagwe. Unlike other civilizations in the rest of the ancient period, the essence and substance of culture was not altered with the change of locations.
- ❖ The Zagwe dynasty emerged in about the middle of the twelfth century
- ❖ Adefa was the political center of the Zagwe dynasty
- ❖ The rock-hewn churches of Lalibela can be grouped into three, based on their location and style of construction.
- ❖ Zagwe rulers had close relations with Egypt and the Holy Land (Jerusalem)
- ❖ Absence of smooth political succession and strong agitation by non-Zagwe opponents as well as the emergence of Zeila as import-export business center resulted in the downfall of Zagwe dynasty in 1270.

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